

THE FOUR OLDS

substance draft v5 – checkpoint 3 rewrite loop

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INT. CABLE NEWS STUDIO - NIGHT

Election night. A wall-sized map, most of it undecided gray. Confetti cannons stand by, unfired.

The board flips a state blue. Then another. A production assistant claps twice, alone, then stops.

ANCHOR

At eleven-oh-four eastern, we can now project — Zoran Marwani, the junior senator from New York, the first DSA-affiliated nominee ever to carry a major party — has been elected President of the United States.

The studio erupts. Balloons fall on the news desk. Someone has printed HISTORY IS HEALING on a bedsheet in the crowd outside the window.

The COMMENTATOR, silver-haired, removes his glasses. His eyes are wet on camera.

COMMENTATOR

Forty-one years I've covered this building. Perhaps tonight — perhaps tonight begins the reconciliation with a world the last administration spent years insulting.

The chyron below him rolls: MARKETS "CAUTIOUS." ALLIES "JUBILANT."

EXT. NATIONAL MALL - DAY

Two months later. Inauguration crowd to the horizon. On the jumbotron, PRESIDENT MARWANI, 41, hand off the Bible, already at the podium. Flags on the stage: the fifty stars, and beside it, same height, the UN blue.

MARWANI

(on the jumbotron)

I do not stand here to celebrate a victory. I stand here to begin a repair. On behalf of the United

States — to every nation we have
wronged — we are sorry.

The crowd roars. The roar rolls down the Mall in a wave.

MARWANI
(on the jumbotron)
This is not retreat. This is not
surrender. This is repair.

Under the podium feed, the chyron: NOBEL COMMITTEE AWARDS
PEACE PRIZE, CITING "THE ANNOUNCED AGENDA."

INT. C-17 CARGO BAY - DAY

Cold metal light. Pallets nose to tail, shrink-wrapped.
Under the plastic: banded bricks of hundred-dollar bills.

A LOADMASTER walks the line with a clipboard manifest.
Stamped across the top page: IRAN COMPENSATION FRAMEWORK —
DISBURSEMENT 1 OF 12.

At the ramp, a young STATE DEPARTMENT AIDE in a
windbreaker turns his back to the pallets, raises his
phone, and takes a selfie. He checks it. Takes a better
one.

INT. GRAND HALL, BRUSSELS - DAY

Chandeliers. A long table of ministers. The U.S. TREASURY
SECRETARY signs a document the size of a phone book; a
European minister pats his shoulder twice.

Champagne comes out on trays. The chyron on the broadcast
feed: U.S. COMMITS \$200 BILLION TO EUROPEAN DEFENSE
RENEWAL. Below it, a stock ticker, all red.

ON A PHONE SCREEN

A push alert stacks over a family photo: WHITE HOUSE
UNVEILS "STEWARDSHIP ACT" — PRIVATE ASSETS ABOVE \$1B TO BE
ADMINISTERED IN THE PUBLIC INTEREST.

A thumb swipes it away. Another alert lands on top of it.

INT. SENATE HEARING ROOM - DAY

Packed gallery. MAGNUS HALE alone at the witness table, reading from a single prepared page. His voice is level and dead.

HALE

Frontier is proud to serve the goals of this administration, at home and beyond it.

SENATOR

"Proud." That's good. Because some of my colleagues feel a capability this essential shouldn't rest in private hands at all. There's a word for the remedy. I want you to hear me say it slowly. Nationalization.

The Senator leans back. Cameras click.

Hale folds his page in half, and in half again, and says nothing.

INT. ROY'S DINER - MORNING

A counter town diner. Six regulars, coffee, forks down. Nobody talks.

On the wall TV, muted: the Brussels champagne, the falling balloons, the jumbotron apology, cycling.

EARLENE, 60s, refills BUCK's cup. Buck, 70s, feed cap, doesn't look up from the counter. The COOK stands in the pass-through window, towel over his shoulder, watching the muted TV. He doesn't move.

Under everything, a radio on the back shelf, volume near zero:

RADIO (V.O.)

...effective January first, the private sale and discharge of consumer fireworks is prohibited nationwide, under the administration's binding carbon framework. Municipal displays may apply for cultural exemption through the...

Nobody moves to turn it up. The percolator finishes. Buck turns his cup a quarter turn on the saucer.

BUCK

Huh.

He drinks.

CUT TO BLACK.

THE FOUR OLDS

INT. FIRST PLAINS BANK, BROKEN BOW, NEBRASKA - DAY

Fluorescent light, carpet tiles, one teller window open. A cardboard sign on an easel by the door: THE STEWARDSHIP ACT — WORKING FOR COMMUNITIES LIKE YOURS. Nobody is looking at it.

CRICKET DAWES, 79, sits in the waiting area. Pressed white shirt, buttoned to the collar. A manila folder square on his knees, both hands on it.

INT. LOAN OFFICE - DAY

The LOAN OFFICER, 30s, tie too new, is on the desk phone as Cricket comes in. He waves him to the chair, mouths sorry.

OFFICER

(into phone)

— no, the culvert's the county's.
That's not ours, tell him to call
Roads. Roads. R-O— I have to go.

He hangs up. Exhales. Checks a sticky note on his monitor.

OFFICER

Mr. Dawes. Sorry. Everybody's got
a flooded something this week.

Cricket sets the folder on the desk and opens it. Tab dividers, fifty years of order. He slides the county letter across.

OFFICER

I've got it on screen, you don't
need—

Cricket slides the assessment appeal receipt across too. The officer takes it to be polite and sets it down without reading it.

CRICKET

County reassessed in March. Four thousand two hundred six dollars, due the fifteenth. I have two thousand one hundred.

OFFICER

(typing)

Okay. So there was a program for exactly this. Hardship deferral on ag-adjacent parcels, it's — hang on.

He reads his screen. Half to himself, losing the thread of it:

OFFICER

"Suspended pending alignment review of county remittance instruments under the" — um. It's paused. Not paused — there's no — there isn't a mechanism right now. Is what that means.

CRICKET

When does it come back?

OFFICER

It doesn't say. It's federal now. The language doesn't — it doesn't say.

A silence. The officer scrolls Cricket's accounts, filling it.

OFFICER

You've banked here — wow. Sixty-one years. That's longer than my dad's been alive.

He stops scrolling. Squints.

ON HIS SCREEN: a recurring deposit line. NASA — \$0.00 QUARTERLY. Account description: DAWES, E. — ASTRONAUT (ACTIVE).

OFFICER

There's a deposit here from NASA.
Every quarter. For zero dollars
and zero cents. That's got to be a
glitch, I can put a ticket in and
get it scrubbed off your—

CRICKET

Leave it.

Too fast. Too hard. The officer looks up. Cricket sits
exactly as he was, level again.

CRICKET

It's been there fifty years. It
can stay.

OFFICER

...Sure.

He closes that window. Sits back. Thinks. Then he pulls a
form from the drawer and talks while he fills it in, not
looking up.

OFFICER

What I can do is — our scanner's
been down, there's a whole tray of
stuff that hasn't been logged,
things get received when they get
received —

He stamps a date box.

OFFICER

— so your paperwork came in next
cycle. That's sixty days before
anything goes delinquent. Don't
tell my branch manager.

He slides the carbon copy across.

OFFICER

Or do, honestly. She does it too.

Cricket looks at the stamp. Puts the copy in the folder,
in order, and stands.

CRICKET

What do I owe you?

OFFICER

It's a bank, Mr. Dawes. You owe us
four thousand dollars.

A beat. Almost a smile out of Cricket. He squares the
folder under his arm and stops at the door, half turned.

CRICKET

Your culvert caller. If that's the
one under Route 12 by the Hollen
place, that's county, he's right.
But Roads won't get to it till
October. Log chain and a tractor,
some Saturday. Hour of work.

OFFICER

...I'll pass that on.

Cricket goes.

EXT. FIRST PLAINS BANK, PARKING LOT - DAY

Cricket sits in his pickup, folder on the bench seat, keys
in his hand. Through the windshield: the courthouse across
the square, and above it, the flag, moving.

He watches it one moment. He starts the truck.

CUT TO:

INT. DAWES BARN - NIGHT

A work light on a beam. Filling half the barn: a homebuilt
simulator - plywood, angle iron, salvaged instrument
panels, a real crew couch bolted to a welded frame. Every
switch is real. Every label is hand-lettered.

Along the back wall, shelving floor to roof: spiral
notebooks, hundreds of them, spines out, each spine dated
in the same hand. The first shelf starts at 1972.

CRICKET, headset on, drops into the couch and brings the
panel up. Breakers click in a practiced order. An amber
bus light steadies.

At his elbow, a ham radio rig glows. He keys it.

CRICKET

Net's open. Tuesday, nineteen-oh-two local.

STITCH (FILTERED)

There he is.

DUTCH (FILTERED)

Bus B first. What's it read.

CRICKET

Twenty-eight point one.

DUTCH (FILTERED)

Huh. Okay. So it held. I still don't like the way it sagged last week. When's the last time you pulled that relay - don't answer, I have it here. '84. You put that relay in in '84.

STITCH (FILTERED)

Is he doing the relay again?

DUTCH (FILTERED)

It's a forty-year-old relay, is all I'm saying. I'm allowed to say it.

GUNNY (FILTERED)

It's nineteen-oh-three, gentlemen. Commander, run your checklist.

CRICKET

Guidance internal. Tanks at sixty-two percent, simulated. Descent program loaded.

The barn door rolls open a foot. PEG, 77, in a house coat, sets a thermos on the workbench.

PEG

Tell Elmore his wife wants him off by ten.

Cricket lifts two fingers off the throttle without looking back. Peg pulls the door to behind her.

STITCH (FILTERED)

Was that Peg?

CRICKET

Coffee's here.

STITCH (FILTERED)

Tell her I said—

DUTCH (FILTERED)

It's an open checklist, people.

Cricket flies. Hands easy on the controls. The panel needles track. Then an ammeter needle drops and wanders. A low buzz under the hum.

CRICKET

Bus B again. Needle's walking.

DUTCH (FILTERED)

That buzz. Steady or does it stutter?

CRICKET

Stutters.

DUTCH (FILTERED)

Inverter case. Kick it, low left corner.

Cricket kicks the case, low left corner. The needle climbs home. The buzz quits.

Nobody says anything about it. The checklist goes on.

CRICKET

Three hundred feet. Drifting left. Correcting.

Silence on the net. Only the hum and the switch clicks. His hands make small moves. The rate needle eases down. Down.

A panel lamp lights: CONTACT.

CRICKET

Contact light. Engine stop.

A beat of quiet on the net.

STITCH (FILTERED)

Hair late on the throttle there at the end.

GUNNY (FILTERED)

The man is on the ground, Colonel.

STITCH (FILTERED)

I'm just saying what I saw.

CRICKET

Net closed. Same time Tuesday.

DUTCH (FILTERED)

God willing.

Cricket keys the mic twice — two clicks. Two clicks come back. Then two more. Then two more. He powers the rig down.

He takes a fresh spiral notebook page and writes, ballpoint, block letters: T+2,806. BUS B CORRECTED. CONTACT 19:41. CREW PRESENT BY RADIO.

He shelves the notebook with the others. Runs his thumb once down the dated spines on his way to the light switch — 1974, 1988, 2003 — and pulls the cord.

EXT. DAWES BARN - NIGHT

Cricket rolls the door shut and snaps a padlock through the hasp. He tests it with one pull.

Beyond the barn, the farmhouse porch light.

He crosses to the house, thermos under his arm.

CUT TO:

INT. DAWES FARMHOUSE, KITCHEN - NIGHT

Supper cleared. Peg dries dishes at the sink. Cricket at the kitchen table with the county tax letter, a legal pad, and a pencil, doing long division he's already done twice.

The wall phone rings. Curly cord. Cricket takes it standing.

CRICKET

Dawes.

INT. DANNY'S KITCHEN, KEARNEY - NIGHT - INTERCUT

DANNY DAWES, 50, stands in his own kitchen, TV light moving on the wall behind him, remote in his free hand.

DANNY

Hey, Dad. Roads are clear down here, finally. They got the sale barn running Thursdays again, so that's - Rachel says hi. Kids are good.

CRICKET

Good.

DANNY

Yeah.

A pause. Danny looks at his TV. Presses mute.

DANNY

Dad. Maybe don't watch the news tonight.

Cricket stands there a second. Peg has stopped drying.

CRICKET

Thank you for calling.

He hangs up. Crosses to the parlor TV and turns it on.

INT. DAWES FARMHOUSE, PARLOR - CONTINUOUS

On the screen: the White House briefing room, then MARWANI at a lectern, flanked by the UN flag and a folded blue banner on a stand.

MARWANI

(on TV)

Tonight I can announce the Lunar Heritage Neutralization Accord. Fifty-seven years ago, one nation planted its banner on ground that belongs to all mankind. Not as conquest, we were told. And yet the banner stayed. It stayed through every apology we owed and never gave.

Peg comes to the parlor doorway, dish towel over her shoulder.

MARWANI

(on TV)

Science tells us those six flags
are bleached white now — fifty
years of unfiltered sun. Some call
those flags of surrender. I call
them flags of peace. Let this be
our gesture to the rest of the
world: we come in peace. We will
retire them with dignity. We will
return them to Earth. And we will
gift them — one to each nation
America has wronged. The first, to
the people of Iran.

The screen cuts to a graphic. On the left: the archive photo, Aldrin's salute, the flag hard-colored against black. On the right: a computer rendering of the same flag, boiled white, captioned ARTIST'S RENDERING — CURRENT CONDITION.

MARWANI

(on TV)

In their place will fly the
Harmony Banner — designed by a
committee of forty-four nations.
Not one nation's pride. Not one
nation's claim. One planet's
promise. The retrieval will be
broadcast live, this coming July
fourth. Not Independence Day. This
year, the first Unity Day.

Applause from the briefing room press corps. Marwani does not smile. He nods, slowly, eyes down.

Peg picks a dish back up and dries it. Dries it harder. Sets it down in the rack with a crack of china on china that makes no one flinch because no one else is there.

Cricket watches to the end of the segment. An ANCHOR comes back on.

ANCHOR

(on TV)

— being called the most generous
act in the history of spaceflight.

Cricket turns the set off. Sets the remote down square on
the arm cover. Stands a moment in the dark parlor.

Then he goes back to the kitchen, takes the wall phone off
the hook, and dials from memory — seven digits, then four
more.

CRICKET
(into phone)
You watching this?

DUTCH (V.O.)
(through the phone)
Both channels. They're running
that white mock-up every ten
minutes.

Neither man says anything. On the muted parlor TV behind
Cricket, visible through the doorway: the white rendering
again, full screen.

CRICKET
(into phone)
Tuesday. Early.

He hangs the phone on its cradle, gently.

CUT TO:

EXT. DAWES FARM - DAY

Two black SUVs come up the drive doing about half the
speed of the county flatbed truck behind them. They park
in a row, doors open together.

Cricket steps off the porch and stands waiting, shoulders
back.

ADMINISTRATOR PELL, 50s, lanyard over a zip fleece, gets
out reading a folder, and doesn't look at Cricket at all.
Behind him a COUNTY DEPUTY, 40s, and four MOVERS in
matching polos.

PELL
Mr. Dawes! There he is. This is a
routine action, sir, nothing

dramatic. The county's executing
on the delinquent assessment —
that's their side. I'm only here
for the federal paperwork.

CRICKET

The bank logged my paperwork
received next cycle. I have sixty
days.

PELL

That's the bank. The bank isn't
the county. And neither one of
them is federal. You're dealing
with three separate systems today,
Mr. Dawes. They don't wait on each
other. Nobody's done anything
wrong here.

He hands Cricket a pink sheet without stopping his walk to
the barn.

INT. DAWES BARN - CONTINUOUS

The movers roll the door wide. Daylight falls across the
simulator.

MOVER #1: What is this thing?

Nobody answers him. Pell circles the rig, checking it
against an inventory sheet.

PELL

Item one. Homebuilt trainer,
gyroscopic couch, panels — one
altitude indicator—

CRICKET

Attitude.

Pell looks at the sheet. Makes a small correction with his
pen.

PELL

Noted.

He peels a long orange sticker off a backing sheet and
lays it across the main panel, smoothing it down with his

thumb: FEDERAL INTEREST — SENSITIVE AEROSPACE TRAINING
APPARATUS — EXCLUDED FROM PUBLIC AUCTION.

CRICKET

Excluded from auction. So the
county can't even sell it to cover
the taxes. Then this isn't about
the taxes.

PELL

Everything's compliance now. It's
fairer that way. Same rules for
everybody.

The movers unbolt the crew couch. A ratchet slips; a mover
barks a knuckle and swears; Cricket hands him the correct
socket off the pegboard. The mover takes it and can't look
at him.

The Deputy stands near the door with his thumbs in his
belt, studying the dirt floor.

Pell reaches the logbook wall. Hundreds of dated spines.
He runs his pen light along a shelf, pulls one notebook,
flips three pages of grid-ruled block printing.

PELL

Personal papers.

He drops it back in its slot, crooked.

PELL

No salvage value. Leave them.

The first dolly rolls toward the door with the crew couch
strapped to it — and stops.

Cricket is standing in the doorway. Square in it, feet
set, hands at his sides.

The mover looks back at Pell. Pell looks at Cricket.

PELL

Mr. Dawes. This is executed. It's
paper now.

Cricket doesn't move. Doesn't say anything either. The
barn goes quiet, six men standing around fifty years on a
dolly.

Pell nods at the Deputy.

The Deputy comes over slow, and stops in front of Cricket, close, hat in his hand.

DEPUTY

Earl.

CRICKET

You'll have to move me, Wade.

Wade stands there a moment. Then he puts his hat on, takes Cricket's arm with both hands, gentle, and walks him three steps aside – and Cricket lets him, because it's Wade.

The dolly rolls past. Cricket's eyes never leave the couch, all the way onto the flatbed.

EXT. DAWES FARM - LATER

The simulator rides the flatbed in pieces, chained at four corners.

The movers file past the porch. Peg holds the screen door open for them and nods each one through.

PEG

Doorframe's fresh painted. Mind
it.

The Deputy is last. He hands Cricket the county copy, folded small.

DEPUTY

There's an appeal window at the
courthouse. It's open till four.

CRICKET

Thank you, Wade.

The Deputy gets in his cruiser. Pell pauses at his SUV door and takes in the farm, the barn, the sky. He nods at each.

PELL

Folks, I know change feels sudden.
But as the Accord reminds us –
harmony is a verb.

He gets in. The convoy pulls out, flatbed last. Dust hangs over the drive and settles.

INT. DAWES BARN - DUSK

The barn, half empty. Where the simulator stood: a clean rectangle of dust, bolt holes at the corners.

Cricket stands at its edge. Peg comes in and stands next to him. Neither says anything for a while. Straight backs, both of them.

PEG

Supper's on in twenty.

She goes. Cricket looks at the rectangle one more moment.

Then he crosses to the workbench — they left the radio — pulls the stool in, and keys the mic.

CRICKET

(into mic)

Net's open. Wednesday.

Static. Then, fast:

DUTCH (FILTERED)

Copy Wednesday.

STITCH (FILTERED)

Copy.

GUNNY (FILTERED)

About time.

Cricket sets the mic down and reaches up and pulls the work light on.

CUT TO:

INT. ROY'S DINER - DAY

Lunch rush. Nine customers. The TV is up loud now.

ON THE TV: a Unity Day promo. A loft apartment somewhere with exposed brick and forty people in matching UNITY DAY shirts, cheering a countdown clock. Below them the crawl: 62 DAYS TO UNITY DAY — NATIONS OF HONOR ANNOUNCED FRIDAY.

At the counter: BUCK, same stool. WADE the deputy, in uniform, eating eggs two stools down, hat crown-up on the counter beside him.

The COOK works the flat-top. Zip-tied to the gas line at his elbow: a gray box with a digital readout and a county seal. It ticks up as he cooks.

COOK
(to the box)
Yeah, I see you.

The diner door bell rings. Cricket comes in, takes the end stool. Earlene has coffee in front of him before he's square on the seat. She doesn't write a ticket. Down the counter, nobody turns his way. Buck slides the sugar caddy to within Cricket's reach without looking up from the TV.

ON THE TV: the watch-party promo gives way to a panel. The white ARTIST'S RENDERING fills the screen again.

PANELIST
(on TV)
— and honestly the flags are the last piece of it. This is a president finishing an argument America started losing in 1969—

BUCK
Fifty years we kept commies off the Moon. Turns out all they had to do was win a primary.

EARLENE
Buck.

BUCK
I said it quiet.

Wade's cup has been empty a while. Earlene stands three feet from the pot, wiping the counter. Wade looks at the cup, then doesn't look at it again. He slides two dollars under the saucer, takes his hat, and goes. The bell rings behind him.

The Cook flips the TV with the remote — to the ball game, pregame, crowd shots from a half-empty stadium.

STADIUM ANNOUNCER
(on TV)

...invite you to rise, as
tonight's ceremonies open with
"One World Rising," performed by
the Tri-Cities Children's Harmony
Choir.

A synthesizer swells on the broadcast. On screen, some of
the crowd stands. A lot of it doesn't.

The Cook turns the sound down, not off, and goes back to
the flat-top.

Buck, not looking up from his coffee, starts humming. Low,
to himself. Four notes in, it's the anthem.

The Cook's spatula picks up the time against the grill
edge, small, maybe not even on purpose. At the register,
Earlene hums the next bar while she counts a stranger's
change.

Nobody stands. Nobody looks at anybody. The counter hums
it to the end of the verse and stops, and the diner goes
back to forks and plates.

Cricket finishes his coffee, reaches for his wallet.

EARLENE

It's paid.

Cricket looks down the counter. Buck watches the ball
game.

CRICKET

Obliged.

He puts his cap on and goes. The bell rings. Through the
window, his pickup pulls out, and beyond it, across the
square, the courthouse flag on its pole.

The meter on the gas line ticks up. The Cook watches it a
second. Then he goes back to the grill.

CUT TO:

INT. AMERICAN LEGION POST 219, BACK ROOM - NIGHT

A wood stove, folding chairs, a percolator going. On the
wall, unit photos going back to Korea.

GUNNY TIBBS, 71, squares the folding chairs to the table, exact. DUTCH HAAS, 76, sits with a thick ring binder in front of him, closed, both hands on it. STITCH MCGREW, 74, is tipped back on two legs of his chair, hat over one knee.

Cricket comes in, takes off his cap.

STITCH

You're shorter than you sound on
the radio.

CRICKET

You're older.

GUNNY

Gentlemen. Sit where I put you.

They sit. A beat. Four faces that have been voices for years, taking each other in.

DUTCH

Before anyone says anything. I've
been talking to a fella at
Frontier. Cargo side, twenty
years. He's sound. I'd sign for
him. Hear him out.

A knock. Gunny opens the door.

MACK BOONE, 55, work jacket, comes in with a thermos under one arm and a folder under the other. He nods to the room, sets both down, and lays one sheet flat in the middle of the table, squared to the edges.

Nobody touches it. Then Dutch rotates it with two fingers, reads two lines, and goes very still.

INSERT — THE PAGE: a federal cargo manifest. Across the header: LUNAR HERITAGE NEUTRALIZATION ACCORD — ARTIFACT RETRIEVAL. Line items: SIX (6) CONTAINMENT UNITS, CLASS-A ARCHIVAL. OUTBOUND CONFIGURATION: EMPTY.

MACK

Six museum-grade containment
units. Class-A archival spec.
Launching the last week of June,
riding up empty. Somebody has to
build them, and it isn't Frontier
— the fab shop's closed, you read

the papers. So it goes out to a contractor, and the contractor's been given a budget with a note on it.

He opens the folder, takes out a printed email, and reads it flat.

MACK

"Containment units are non-crew hardware. No certification pathway required. Recommend sourcing retired fabrication and aerospace personnel at heritage-labor rates."

He sets the email down next to the manifest.

MACK

Heritage-labor rates. That's you, gentlemen. That's this whole room.

Silence. The stove ticks. Dutch reads the header a second time. Stitch reads it upside down from across the table. Gunny reads it and then looks at Mack for a long moment, and Mack holds the look and offers nothing.

STITCH

(quiet)

Cheap old men. To box up the—

He doesn't finish it. Nobody finishes it.

GUNNY

(to the room, not
to Mack)

Somebody is going to build those boxes. Somebody's going to fold those colors into them, on live television, with the whole world grading the job. I'd sooner it be men who know how a flag is handled than whoever else answers that email.

He picks up the email, reads it again, sets it down.

GUNNY

We're the whoever-else, boys.

A short, hard laugh around the table — Stitch first. Not a happy sound, but a real one.

DUTCH

(off the spec page)

This is my standard. The '98
archival spec. Word for word.

MACK

Nobody's improved it. Man who
wrote it builds to it — that part
of the pitch writes itself.

Cricket hasn't said anything the whole meeting. Now he puts his cap on, pushes his chair back, and walks out. The door bangs. Through the window, his pickup's dome light comes on.

The room holds. Gunny looks at Mack. Mack doesn't move.

The door bangs again and Cricket comes back in carrying logbooks — a two-arm load of spiral notebooks, dust still on the covers. He drops them on the table, on top of the manifest, hard enough to jump the coffee cups.

Fifty years of Tuesdays, dated spine after dated spine.

CRICKET

I'm current.

Mack takes the top logbook. Flips it open. Turns a page, then another, slower.

MACK

Every Tuesday. Fifty years.

He closes it and sets it down, careful now, square on the stack, with both hands.

MACK

You'll do. Build starts Monday.

He deals contract packets around the table from the folder, one in front of each man. Pens come out. Nobody reads past the first page except Dutch, who reads all of it.

At the door, thermos back under his arm, Mack stops.

MACK

One more thing, and it's in the paperwork. Client's particular about the shop. No phones inside. No pictures. No talk — not at the diner, not at church, not on your radios. Company confidentiality.

STITCH

Confidential flag boxes.

MACK

That's the job.

He goes. The four of them sit with their contract packets. Gunny gathers the coffee cups, one at a time, thinking.

CUT TO:

INT. FRONTIER AEROSPACE, FABRICATION BAY 2 - DAY

A cathedral of a shop floor. Gantry cranes, weld curtains, a bell nozzle the size of a grain silo up on stands. Two hundred workers in company blues stand in loose ranks, hoods up, gloves off.

Among them: TITO ALVAREZ, 24, welding hood pushed back, a smear of soot to the jaw.

At a portable lectern: MIRA VESS, 40s, charcoal suit, no notes. Off her shoulder, ADMINISTRATOR PELL with a tablet, recording. At the back of the ranks, MACK BOONE stands with his arms folded.

VESS

I will not waste your morning.
Under the Compliance Monitorship,
Frontier's fabrication footprint
exceeds the mission profile the
government has assigned us.
Effective today, Bay Two is
closed. Two hundred positions are
eliminated.

Silence. Then a stir through the ranks, voices low and getting less low.

WORKER

My father cut the first nozzle
ring in this bay!

VESS

I know he did. His name is on the wall of the visitor center.

She turns a page on the lectern, unhurried, while the ranks stare.

VESS

Terms. Severance is twelve months at full rate. Health coverage carries the same twelve. The tooling and heavy equipment will be declared surplus and sold for scrap at public auction. Shop inventory will be palletized and dispositioned by an outside logistics contractor.

Mack, at the back, unfolds his arms.

VESS

Each of you carries a priority-rehire designation, should operations resume. I do not expect you to believe that means anything. Keep the card anyway.

She closes the folder on the lectern. Looks out at two hundred faces that hate her.

VESS

Last thing. Whatever you need to think about today – put it on me.

She steps off the lectern. No questions invited, none asked. Pell taps his tablet and leans toward her.

PELL

For the record, the Monitorship views this as a – a meaningful posture of alignment. I'll be noting the, ah, expedited timeline favorably.

VESS

Note whatever you like.

She walks the length of the bay to the doors, heels on concrete the only sound, two hundred men watching her go.

LATER

The ranks have broken up. Men pack toolboxes. A news crew shoots through the fence gate: workers filing out with toolboxes and milk crates.

Tito stands at his station a last moment. On the bench: a practice weld, two plates joined by a bead like a row of dimes. He raps it twice with one knuckle, picks up his hood, and walks out past Mack.

MACK

Alvarez.

TITO

Mr. Boone.

MACK

You paid up at the union hall?

TITO

Through March.

Mack picks up the practice weld off the bench — the two joined plates — turns it over once, and sets it back down.

MACK

Keep your tools.

TITO

I just got fired, Mr. Boone.

MACK

I know what happened. Keep your tools.

Mack is already walking. Tito stands there with his toolbox, looking after him, then down at the weld on the bench.

Across the bay, Mack takes a small pocket notebook from his jacket, writes one line, and puts it away.

CUT TO:

EXT. TRI-COUNTY AUCTION BARN - DAY

A steel warehouse the size of a football field, weeds in the gravel apron. The old county sign — CLOSED BY ORDER —

has a new one bolted over half of it: VALLEY SALVAGE & SURPLUS - CONTRACT SITE 4. AUTHORIZED PERSONNEL.

Pickups roll in off the section road, honest daylight, work boots stepping down.

INT. TRI-COUNTY AUCTION BARN - DAY

Mack throws breakers one at a time. Sodium lamps bang on, row by row, until the whole dead acreage of the place stands lit: empty auction floor, intact gantry crane, scale pit, loading docks.

The four olds stand in the middle of it, turning slowly.

DUTCH

Three-phase power. Sixty-foot clear span. A certified scale.

MACK

Client rents it by the month. Cheaper than a real shop, which is the whole spirit of the thing.

The man-door opens. JOSS REED, 26, hoodie, work boots, a duffel. Behind him, TITO, toolbox in hand, hood under his arm.

MACK

Joss runs my dock at Frontier days; evenings he's mine. Fastest hands I've got. Tito you know by his work - Bay Two, before the cuts.

JOSS

(seeing the old men)

Mack says be here at five and bring nothing with a battery, which is like - literally everything is a battery - so I brought Tito.

GUNNY

Son. Phones.

Gunny holds out a coffee can. Joss looks at it. Looks at the four old men looking at him.

MACK

Client confidentiality. It's in everybody's paperwork.

Joss drops his phone in. Tito's follows.

Mack unrolls the drawings on a plywood table — official sheets, title block stamped with a federal contract number. A crate, in section. Dimensions, purge lines, a battery bus, a padded interior mount drawn to close tolerance.

The kids lean in. Joss reads the header.

JOSS

Wait. These are for the — we're building the flag boxes? So the plan is we build fake ones and switch them, right, and the flags never actually come down? That's the play?

MACK

The play is we build six containment units to federal spec and deliver them on time. It's a job, son. First one anybody's offered Bay Two men since March.

Joss looks around the room. Nobody gives him anything.

JOSS

Okay. Sure. A job.

Tito hasn't looked up from the drawing. He rotates it with one finger, frowning.

TITO

This corner joint. You spec'd a fillet here?

DUTCH

Full-penetration bevel. Page two.

TITO

For a box that rides up empty and comes back with a flag in it? That's a weld for something that can't ever be allowed to fail.

DUTCH

The spec says what it says.

TITO

(turning the page)

Okay. Okay, yeah. But your purge line comes through two inches from the weld. Heat's going to cook your fitting. Move it here, come in under the frame rail, nobody ever sees it.

Dutch looks at the drawing. Looks at Tito. Takes out a pencil and hands it to him.

Tito takes it, bends over the sheet, and starts drawing the new line.

Dutch moves down the drawing as Tito works — and stops at the interior mount detail. Reads the dimensions. Reads them again.

DUTCH

Generous interior. You could put a man in this.

A beat. Then Stitch snorts.

STITCH

Government money. They'd gold-plate a mailbox.

DUTCH

(still looking at the sheet)

Hm.

He turns the page and moves on.

LATER

Tito, on his knees on the concrete, chalks a full-size crate outline on the floor off the drawings — a long rectangle, corners squared off a framing square.

The men stand around it, looking down at the empty chalk, each of them quiet a beat longer than a box deserves.

Mack checks his watch, takes the coffee can of phones under his arm, and kills the lights row by row on his way

out.

CUT TO:

INT. TRI-COUNTY AUCTION BARN - DAY

The auction floor is a training floor now. A taped lane down the concrete. A wooden step box. Four army cots. An eye chart hung on the far wall, a long way off.

Dutch sits at a child's school desk, the binder open beside a stack of carbon-copy forms. The top form, fresh-printed to match a fifty-eight-year-old original: FLIGHT CREW MEDICAL EXAMINATION — STANDARDS OF 1968.

DUTCH

Gentlemen. NASA wrote a physical in 1968. It is the last standard that ever mattered, and it is the one in this binder. We do all of it or none of it.

JOSS

(raising a hand)

Question. Is there a version of this where we just — there's literally an app that does a full—

GUNNY

Son.

Gunny points at Joss's wrist. The smartwatch. Then at the coffee can on the plywood table.

JOSS

It's a WATCH.

GUNNY

Can, son.

JOSS

Okay, okay — last thing it does, then. Science. For science. Second question. Why does a crate-swapping crew need flight physicals?

MACK

(from the doorway,
not looking up from
his clipboard)
Standards are standards.

Dutch's pencil stops on the form, one beat. Then it keeps writing.

THE STEP TEST

Cricket, sleeves rolled, steps up and down on the box to Gunny's count. Steady the whole count. Joss holds his watch near Cricket's wrist, eyes on the little screen.

Cricket steps down. Stands easy. Breathes through his nose.

JOSS
Two minutes post-exercise...
fifty-four. Resting fifty-one. Old
dude's resting heart rate
embarrassed my watch. My watch
cost four hundred dollars.

None of the old men react to this at all. Dutch writes the number down and points at the box: next.

Joss looks at the watch, then walks it to the coffee can and drops it in.

THE EYE CHART

Stitch, hand over one eye, all the way across the warehouse from the chart.

STITCH
Bottom line's got a print date on
it. You want that too?

DUTCH
(writing)
Line eleven. Nobody reads line
eleven.

THE STEP TEST, AGAIN

Stitch's turn on the box. On the fourth step his knee cracks loud enough to carry across the floor. His cadence doesn't change. He finishes the count and steps down.

Nobody says anything about it. Dutch writes without looking up.

DUTCH

Waiver, page nine. There were waivers in '68 too. Compensating technique documented.

STITCH

Anyway.

THE CRATE

The plywood mockup crate sits in the middle of the floor, lid on. Inside it, unseen: Gunny. On the lid: a wind-up kitchen timer and four twenty-dollar bills under a socket wrench.

Joss and Tito sit on the concrete nearby, backs to a post. Cricket whittles a soft pine peg to fit a knothole.

TITO

(low, to Joss)

Bet's who asks the time first.

The timer ticks. The lid does not move.

The timer rings. Dutch lifts the lid. Gunny sits up, unhurried, looks around at all of them, and settles on the money under the wrench.

GUNNY

Whose twenty is on top?

JOSS

Mine.

GUNNY

It's mine now, son.

AT THE SCHOOL DESK - LATER

Dutch signs the fourth carbon form with a fountain pen. Squares the stack. Files all four into the binder rings and closes the cover.

DUTCH

Same result as 1968. All four.

He packs his fountain pen into its case. Then, as an afterthought:

DUTCH

Slower on the step box. All four of you. I wrote it down.

STITCH

Best year there ever was.

CUT TO:

INT. TRI-COUNTY AUCTION BARN - DAY

The shop, working. Crate number one stands in a welding jig, half-skinned, purge lines run neat along the frame rail where nobody will ever see them. TITO welds, hood down, bead steady.

Around the floor, in twos and threes, MEN FROM BAY TWO work stations — machining, harness-lay, upholstery on a padded interior mount. Day labor, cash rates, nobody complaining where anyone can hear it.

AT THE PRESSURE TEST

Crate one, sealed, gauge lines running to a hand pump. Gunny checks a clipboard, then raps the lid: two knocks — pause — two knocks.

From inside the crate, muffled: two knocks — two knocks.

GUNNY

(to Dutch, off the gauge)

Holding steady.

DUTCH

Cheaper than instrumenting it. A man and a wristwatch.

Inside the crate, by penlight: TITO, wedged next to the gauge, bored, timing the hold on a wind-up watch.

INT. STITCH'S HANGAR, EAST TEXAS - NIGHT

The Tuesday net. Stitch at his workbench rig, two fingers on the key — then off it, onto the mic.

STITCH (INTO MIC): Y'all want to hear something about this job—

DUTCH (FILTERED)
Not on the air.

A beat.

STITCH (INTO MIC): ...Weather's been dry.

INT. DAWES FARMHOUSE, KITCHEN - NIGHT

Supper cleared. Cricket raps the table edge with one knuckle: two, pause, two.

CRICKET
That's how we check the box with a man inside. Two and two — all good. Three, evenly — trouble, open it up.

PEG
And supper?

CRICKET
There's no knock for supper.

Peg raps the table twice, pause, twice — then once, hard, on the sugar bowl lid.

PEG
All good, and there's pie.

Cricket looks at her a moment. Then he gets out his pad and writes it down.

INT. TRI-COUNTY AUCTION BARN - LATE DAY

The big doors stand open to the gold end of the afternoon. Work sounds. Then, one by one, the stations go quiet.

A black Suburban has pulled onto the apron. MACK walks FOUR MEN down the crate line — thirty-somethings, fit, company windbreakers, no names offered. They carry a tablet and a cloth measuring tape.

At the open crate — the padded interior mount finished now — one of them steps out of his shoes, climbs in, and lies

back into the mount while another runs the tape: shoulder width, hip depth, reach. Numbers onto the tablet. They swap. Measure again.

They don't speak to anyone on the floor. They don't smile. Ten minutes, and the Suburban is gravel dust headed for the highway.

The shop goes back to work, slower than before.

Dutch stands where he's been standing the whole time, pencil in his hand, not writing anything.

CUT TO:

INT. FRONTIER AEROSPACE, TRAINING ROOM B - DAY

Drop ceiling, stack chairs, a projector. A sign-in clipboard chained to the door. On the screen: CULTURAL ALIGNMENT — MODULE 7 OF 12 (MANDATORY).

Fifty workers in company blues, arms crossed. MACK in the third row. JOSS near the back, dock vest, sunflower seeds.

At the front, a FACILITATOR, 30s, all teeth, clicker in hand.

FACILITATOR

Okay! Module seven. Heritage. Big one. Now — history gives us frameworks for thinking about the past, and some of them are bolder than others. Slide.

The slide: a stylized portrait of MAO ZEDONG over a rising-sun graphic, and the words: 1966 — A BOLD QUESTION: WHAT DO WE OWE THE PAST?

FACILITATOR

In 1966, Chairman Mao's movement asked exactly that. And their answer was a framework called the Four Olds. Slide.

The slide, in clean sans-serif on harmony blue:

OLD IDEAS. OLD CULTURE. OLD CUSTOMS. OLD HABITS.

FACILITATOR

Old ideas. Old culture. Old
customs. Old habits. Four
categories of inherited weight.
And the movement asked a community
to examine that weight together.
Honestly? As an early framework
for heritage neutralization, it
was ahead of its time.

In the third row, Mack uncaps a pen and copies the slide
into his pocket notebook, word for word, block letters.

The door opens. PELL steps in, tablet against his chest,
and beams at the screen.

PELL

Don't mind me. This is the good
work, folks. Centuries of ancient
Chinese wisdom in that slide.

FACILITATOR

It's from 1966—

PELL

Wonderful.

He stays, standing against the wall. The Facilitator
clicks on.

FACILITATOR

Now. Nobody is saying our
situation is identical. But when
we watch the Accord retire tired
symbols this July, we're
participating in that same brave
tradition of asking: does this
still serve us?

JOSS

(not raising his
hand)

What happened to the people who
liked the old stuff?

Silence. The Facilitator's smile holds its position.

FACILITATOR

There were — implementation
errors. In that era. Which is why

today's frameworks center
dialogue. Slide.

The slide: YOUR REFLECTION HOMEWORK — IDENTIFY ONE OLD
HABIT YOU'RE READY TO RETIRE!

FACILITATOR

Small group shares on Thursday.
Sign the clipboard on your way
out, it feeds your compliance
score.

Chairs scrape. Fifty men file out past the clipboard,
signing without slowing down. Pell holds the door, nodding
at each man like he knows him.

IN THE CORRIDOR

Joss falls in beside Mack in the crowd.

JOSS

(low)

My grandpa's old habit was getting
shot at over Hanoi.

MACK

Write "coffee." Everybody writes
coffee.

Joss looks at him. Mack peels off toward the dock without
another word, notebook square in his jacket pocket.

CUT TO:

EXT. FRONTIER LAUNCH COMPLEX - DAY (NEWS FOOTAGE)

Steady news-helicopter footage: the booster on its
transporter, long as a grain elevator on its side. On its
flank, fifty feet of painted stars and stripes.

A cherry-picker rises alongside. Two painters in white
roll primer over the field of stars, top to bottom, one
pass at a time. The footage does not cut away. The anchor
has stopped talking.

INT. FRONTIER AEROSPACE, PRESS ROOM - DAY

Vess at a podium. Cameras. A REPORTER mid-question.

REPORTER

— but whose decision was it to
paint over the—

VESS

Mine. I ordered the repainting.
The Accord specifies neutral
mission livery. Paint is cheaper
than a receiver. That math is my
job.

REPORTER

And Mr. Hale's position on—

VESS

The board meets Thursday. Bring
it.

She steps down.

INT. ROY'S DINER - DAY

The repaint footage on the wall TV, the white roller
crossing the last star.

The Cook reaches up and turns the set off. Black screen.
He goes back to the grill. Nine customers eat in the
quiet. The carbon meter ticks.

The door bell rings. Cricket comes in, takes the end
stool.

Nobody says anything. But Buck doesn't slide the sugar
down, and Earlene's coffee takes a while getting there,
and when it comes she writes the ticket.

Cricket drinks his coffee alone, pays the ticket, and puts
his cap on. The bell rings behind him.

INT. FRONTIER AEROSPACE, HALE'S OFFICE - DUSK

Floor-to-ceiling glass. MAGNUS HALE stands at it, hands in
his pockets, looking down the flight line at the real
thing: the booster, primer-white flank drying under the
work lights. A crew tarps it for the night.

The door. Vess comes in, stops beside him at the glass.
They stand there, not looking at each other, the white

rectangle below them.

She sets a folder on his desk on her way out. The door closes.

Hale doesn't turn around.

CUT TO:

EXT. PIONEER FIELD, MINOR-LEAGUE BALLPARK - NIGHT

Small park, big lights, maybe nine thousand people. Kids on the outfield berm. The four olds and Peg sit together down the third-base line, ball caps and popcorn — and a full row of empty seats on either side of them, in a sold-out park.

PA ANNOUNCER (V.O.)

Ladies and gentlemen, please rise,
as tonight's ceremonies open with
"One World Rising," performed by
the Tri-Cities Children's Harmony
Choir.

The crowd gets up slow, hands in pockets. A backing track swells through the PA — synthesizer, chimes. The children's choir starts, small and dutiful, on the infield grass.

Down the first-base line, BUCK — feed cap in his fist, flannel tucked in for the occasion — stands looking at the flag pole beyond center field, the flag up there lit against the dark.

Buck opens his mouth and starts to sing. The other anthem. The real one. Alone, off-key, too loud, four full bars by himself against nine thousand people's silence and a children's choir.

Nobody joins him. Then the row behind him joins him.

Then the section. Then the far bleachers, ragged, out of time with each other, gaining. The backing track keeps playing underneath, chimes and all, buried under the voices. The children's choir looks at their director. The director looks at nine thousand people, drops her hands, and turns around to face the flag pole.

The four olds do not sing. Hats off, on their feet. Gunny stands at attention, thumb along his trouser seam. Stitch's jaw is tight. Dutch holds his cap over the exact center of his chest. Cricket watches the stands — not the field, the people, row on row of them finding the words.

Peg sings.

By the last line it is nine thousand voices and no melody to speak of and the light towers humming over all of it.

The note dies off across the parking lots. A beat of quiet.

By the concourse rail, a COMPLIANCE KID, 20s, polo and lanyard, stands with his tablet half-raised. He looks from the tablet to the stands and back. He lowers the tablet and puts it away.

The crowd sits. The game just starts, like nothing happened, first pitch a called strike.

On the scoreboard: TONIGHT'S POST-GAME LIGHT SHOW BROUGHT TO YOU BY THE UNITY FUND. A BOY, 8, two rows down from the olds, tugs his father's sleeve.

BOY

Is the light show the one with the booms?

FATHER

Not anymore, bud.

Cricket looks down the row. Dutch, Stitch, Gunny look back at him. Nobody says anything. They sit, and put their caps back on, one by one.

CUT TO:

INT. TRI-COUNTY AUCTION BARN - NIGHT

Late. One work lamp. DUTCH alone at the plywood table with the build drawings, his binder, and a slide rule.

He counts scrubber cartridges on the parts shelf against a line in the drawing. Counts again. Sits down slow.

He works the slide rule. Writes a figure. Works it again from the other direction, and writes the same figure, and

boxes it, twice.

INSERT - THE PAD: CO2 SCRUBBER CAPACITY: 62 HRS. × 4.

Dutch looks at the boxed line a long time. Then he gets up, crosses to crate number one - finished, gleaming under the tarp - pulls the tarp off, undogs the lid, and opens it.

Inside: a molded couch. Head cradle. Restraint webbing. Shaped exactly like a man.

Dutch stands there looking into it a long time, one hand on the lid.

INT. TRI-COUNTY AUCTION BARN - THE NEXT EVENING

All of them: the four olds, Joss, Tito, and MACK, called in. The build drawing lies on the plywood table with Dutch's pad on top of it, the boxed figure facing up.

DUTCH

I ran the numbers twice. Sixty-two hours of breathing air, times four units. You don't put breathing in a decoy. There is no version of this drawing where nobody's inside it.

He turns the drawing around to face Mack.

DUTCH

It's a life-support system with a museum sticker on it. I should know. I wrote it.

He lets that sit one beat.

DUTCH

And those four young fellas with the measuring tape stopped coming around. So. Who's riding, Boone?

Silence. Joss looks from Dutch to Mack. Tito has stopped moving.

Mack looks around the table, one face at a time, and says it plain.

MACK

So. You gentlemen want to go to
the Moon?

Joss sits down on a sawhorse without checking it's there.

JOSS

Wait. WAIT.

MACK

The mission flies July first no
matter what this building does.
Six crates go up empty and six
flags come down. Or four crates go
up full. That's the whole choice.
There isn't a third thing.

GUNNY

And if this room says no?

MACK

Then six crates fly empty, and I
lose track of some scrap, and we
all went to a lot of trouble over
a carousel.

Quiet. The stove has no fire in it tonight, and nobody
moves to light one.

Stitch gets up, walks to the open crate, and looks into
the couch a moment. Then he climbs in, lies back, and sets
his hat on his chest.

STITCH

Snug.

Gunny crosses to the gear shelf and starts counting
scrubber cartridges into ranks of four, marking the shelf
edge with a grease pencil.

GUNNY

Well. Now what do they take from
us - cancel my Medicare on the
Moon?

Dutch squares his pad on the drawing.

DUTCH

The spec holds. I sized it.

Every face turns to Cricket, last.

Cricket looks at the crate a long moment. Then he walks over to it, sits down on the edge of it, and starts unlacing his boots.

CRICKET

Somebody time me getting in. We'll want a number.

Tito comes over and raps the crate wall twice with one knuckle.

TITO

(quiet)

She'll hold.

JOSS

You're all insane. What do you need from me?

MACK

The build order changes Monday. Nothing else does.

He takes out the pocket notebook, writes one line, and puts it away.

CUT TO:

INT. TRI-COUNTY AUCTION BARN - NIGHT

The shop after hours. The crew — four olds, two kids, Mack — around the plywood table. The finished crate with the couch in it stands lid-open where everyone can see it, because nobody's pretending anymore.

MACK

From tonight, everything changes how it moves. Nothing electronic. No phones, no email, no cloud. Nothing with a battery you didn't build yourself.

JOSS

Then how do two hundred guys and four states coordinate a—

DUTCH

Handwritten letters. The ham net,
on schedule, in code. A book
cipher - Cricket has the year and
the month.

Cricket sets a swollen 1971 Reader's Digest on the table.

JOSS

That's insane. That's - that's
Revolutionary War stuff.

GUNNY

They've got every algorithm ever
written. We've got Valley Forge.

Joss opens his mouth. Closes it.

EXT. RURAL MAILBOX, NEBRASKA - DAY

A weathered hand puts a letter in a mailbox and raises the
little red flag. The envelope, handwritten: TRI-COUNTY
FEED COOPERATIVE, RE: PARTS.

EXT. MAILBOX ROW, SOUTH CAROLINA LOWCOUNTRY - DAY

Another envelope, another red flag up. The mail carrier
takes it without a glance, tosses it in the tray between
coupon packs.

INT. DAWES FARMHOUSE, KITCHEN - NIGHT

Peg reads from a handwritten strip of paper, glasses down
her nose.

PEG

Fourteen. Two. Nine.

Cricket thumbs the Reader's Digest to page fourteen,
column two, counts nine words down, and writes one word on
a pad.

PEG

Six. One. Eleven.

He flips, counts, writes. Peg looks at the pad over his
shoulder.

PEG
That's a grocery list.

CRICKET
This week it is.

INT. TRI-COUNTY AUCTION BARN - NIGHT

Tito, respirator up, lays a stencil across crate one's flank and rolls paint through it: LOT A — OLD IDEAS. Taped to the crate beside him, his guide: a page torn from a pocket notebook, four lines in Mack's block handwriting.

He peels the stencil, checks the edges, taps the crate twice.

LATER

Tito shoots two frames of the finished couch with a film camera, winds the film down, and drops the canister into a Folgers can half-full of them. The can goes into the bottom of his toolbox.

EXT. GUNNY'S PORCH, SOUTH CAROLINA - NIGHT

A morse key wired to a TV tray. Sweet tea. Gunny sends, slow and exact, frogs loud in the dark past the porch rail.

INT. DAWES BARN - NIGHT

Cricket copies letter groups off the air onto the pad, line after line. He keys two clicks. Two click back.

EXT. DAWES BARN - LATER

The barn window lit. Inside, faint, morse ticking.

Peg crosses the yard in her house coat, stops at the barn wall, raps it twice — pause — twice. Goes back to the house.

Inside the barn, without breaking his copy rhythm, Cricket reaches up and flicks the work light off-on once.

CUT TO:

EXT. DAWES FARM - DAY

A commercial flatbed grinds up the drive - VALLEY SALVAGE & SURPLUS painted on the door. On the bed, chained at four corners: the simulator, in its pieces.

Every piece wears a fresh orange stencil: SCRAP - LOT 44-C.

Cricket comes off the porch. The DRIVER, 50s, coveralls, swings down with a clipboard.

DRIVER

You Dawes?

CRICKET

I'm Dawes.

DRIVER

Sign for lot 44-C. Scrap conveyance, buyer's copy. Somebody paid the freight to here, don't ask me who, I drive.

Cricket takes the clipboard. Flips the top page. Reads.

The line items: HOMEBUILT TRAINER COMPONENTS. DISPOSITION: SOLD AS SCRAP - NON-FUNCTIONAL. RELEASED FROM FEDERAL SURPLUS HOLDING BY DISPOSAL CONTRACTOR.

Cricket looks at the flatbed. The panels sit intact under the chains, gauges unbroken, his hand-lettered labels facing the sky.

CRICKET

Says non-functional.

DRIVER

It does say that.

The driver looks at the load, then at Cricket, then at his watch.

DRIVER

I got a two o'clock in Ogallala.

Cricket signs. The driver unbinds the chains.

Peg watches from the porch as the two men walk the pieces into the barn on a hand truck, one load at a time.

PEG
Barn's where it was.

DRIVER
Yes, ma'am.

INT. DAWES BARN - NIGHT

The simulator stands whole again on its welded frame, bolted down through the same four holes. The orange SCRAP stencil still on the couch rail. Cricket, socket wrench in hand, looks at the stencil a moment – and leaves it.

He drops into the couch. Breakers click in the practiced order. The amber bus light steadies.

He pulls the headset on and keys the rig.

CRICKET
Net's open. Tuesday.

STITCH (FILTERED)
There he is.

DUTCH (FILTERED)
Bus B. What's it read.

CRICKET
Twenty-eight point four. Better
than it left.

A beat on the net.

GUNNY (FILTERED)
Run your card, Commander.

Cricket sets his hand on the throttle. Above the panel, taped where a mission patch would go: the pink county seizure sheet, folded to show the words SENSITIVE AEROSPACE TRAINING APPARATUS.

CRICKET
Guidance internal.

CUT TO:

INT. FRONTIER AEROSPACE, CARGO INTEGRATION HALL - DAY

Clean-room bright. Six crates on cradles in a row – museum-grade, brushed alloy skins, purge fittings, gauges. Stenciled big on their flanks like stock lots:

LOT A – OLD IDEAS. LOT B – OLD CULTURE. LOT C – OLD CUSTOMS. LOT D – OLD HABITS. LOT E – SUPPLEMENTARY CONTAINMENT. LOT F – SUPPLEMENTARY CONTAINMENT.

Dock crew in bunny suits. MACK with a clipboard. JOSS on the crane controls. And walking the line with a tablet: PELL.

PELL

Random re-weigh. Compliance is a rhythm, folks. Random means random.

MACK

They weighed in at fabrication.

PELL

And now they'll weigh in at integration.

The crane takes LOT A. Sets it on the floor scale. The SCALE TECH, 40s, coffee thermos on the console, reads the number against the manifest.

SCALE TECH

Lot A. Three-eighty declared... four-eleven-two.

Pell stops walking.

PELL

Again.

SCALE TECH

Four-eleven-two.

PELL

Weigh B.

LOT B: 413.0. LOT C: 412.6. LOT D: 409.8. Four crates, all heavy, thirty-some kilos each. Pell comes to the console and reads the display himself – manifest line, crate serial, number, in the right order, fast.

PELL

Thirty kilos over, times four
crates. That's a hundred and
twenty kilos of something, Mr.
Boone.

MACK

Could be the couch upgrade.
Archival spec revision come
through in March—

PELL

Re-run it. Cell check first.

The hall has gone quiet enough to hear the air handlers.

The Scale Tech runs the load-cell check. Taps cell three
with two knuckles. The number stutters: 411.9... 408.2...
413.5.

He frowns at it. Looks up at the crate on the platen — at
the stencil, OLD IDEAS, at the purge gauge holding steady
where a purge gauge should hold. Looks at his own
clipboard.

A long moment. Joss, up in the crane cab, sits absolutely
still.

The Scale Tech writes on the log sheet, reading aloud as
he writes.

SCALE TECH

Calibration drift, cell three. All
four reads invalidated. Corrected
tare applied. Within tolerance
after correction.

He initials it, tears the copy, hands it up to Pell, picks
up his thermos, and walks back to his console. He does not
look at Mack on the way.

Pell reads the sheet. Reads it again. Files it in his
packet, squared to the corner.

PELL

Hm.

He walks the row one more time and stops at LOT F.

PELL

Where's the environmental cert on this one?

MACK

Rides with the master manifest.

PELL

The master manifest references an attachment E-6. There is no attachment E-6 in my packet.

Mack flips his clipboard. A beat too long.

MACK

That's a paperwork question.
Paperwork's Monday.

PELL

It's Thursday. Lot F is impounded until I hold E-6 in my hand. Forty-eight hours, Mr. Boone, or it comes off the manifest and flies nothing to nowhere.

He peels an orange IMPOUND sticker and smooths it across Lot F's seam with his thumb, both passes, careful.

Then, at LOT D, he stops, takes out a pen, signs the inspection tag himself, and slots it in the holder:
INSPECTED - J. PELL.

PELL

The Accord appreciates everyone's patience today.

He goes. The hall breathes. Joss climbs down from the crane, gray in the face. Mack watches Pell's door swing shut.

MACK

(quiet, to Joss)
Get word up the net. Gunny's gear just went in the penalty box.

CUT TO:

INT. SENATE HEARING ROOM - DAY

The same room from the election-year grilling. The same SENATOR, higher on the dais now. In the witness chair: MIRA VESS, alone, no counsel, water glass untouched.

SENATOR

Ms. Vess. You run Frontier day to day.

VESS

I do.

SENATOR

And Mr. Hale — the founder, your... partner — what does he run?

A small laugh through the gallery at the pause. Vess does not join it.

VESS

Magnus holds the title of founder and chief engineer. Day-to-day authority rests with me. It has for six years.

SENATOR

Has Mr. Hale ever expressed contempt for this administration's space policy? For the Accord?

VESS

Frequently. In colorful terms. I can provide dates.

The gallery stirs. On the press bench, pens move.

SENATOR

You'd testify your own founder is hostile to the mission your company is flying.

VESS

I'd testify he talks. Senator, Magnus Hale has not directed a covert anything in the six years I have run his company. He is not built for quiet. What he thinks arrives in public, at volume, usually by breakfast. You have his feed. Subpoena his drafts folder

if you want the unabridged
edition.

Laughter, open now. The Senator lets it run.

SENATOR

Some of my colleagues feel that
attitude alone justifies a federal
receiver on the company through
Unity Day.

VESS

A receiver would spend six months
finding the bathrooms. Your
broadcast is in nine weeks. The
Accord flies on schedule if the
company stays in the hands that
run it. Mine.

SENATOR

And Mr. Hale?

VESS

Watch him as closely as you like.
You will find a loud man with a
clean calendar.

The Senator sits back and caps his pen.

INT. FRONTIER AEROSPACE, HALE'S OFFICE - CONTINUOUS

Dark but for the wall screen: Vess in the chair, the
chyron — VESS: FOUNDER "NOT BUILT FOR QUIET" — and a phone
in Hale's hand.

On the phone, a draft post, cursor blinking: My COO and
the mother of my children just

His thumb hovers. Holds.

He backspaces it to nothing, sets the phone face down on
the desk, and watches the rest in the dark.

ON THE WALL SCREEN

PANELIST (V.O.)

— because when even Mira Vess
won't defend him, what's left to

defend? The board should thank
her. Frankly the country should.

CUT TO:

EXT. DAWES FARM, MAILBOX - DAY

Cricket walks the drive, takes the mail. Bills, a seed catalog - and one heavy envelope, government linen, eagle on the corner.

INT. DAWES FARMHOUSE, KITCHEN - DAY

The letter flat on the table between them. Peg reads over her glasses.

PEG

(reading)

"...administrative review has
restored annuity status
retroactive to separation...
enclosed disbursement reflects
adjusted back period..."

She slides the check out of the envelope. Looks at the number. Sets it down facing Cricket.

The check: \$184,306.00.

PEG

And the county sent one too.
Lien's released. Taxes marked
satisfied, the whole assessment.

CRICKET

Fifty years, they never paid a
nickel. Zero dollars, zero cents,
every quarter on the dot. Now,
nine weeks before their launch,
somebody in Washington finds my
file and gets generous.

Peg looks at the check. At him.

PEG

It would fix the roof. And the
truck. And the next ten years.

CRICKET

It would.

He picks up the check, evens its edges against the table, opens the hutch drawer, and lays it inside, flat, under the county's pink seizure copy he never threw away.

He shuts the drawer.

CRICKET

If they're paying the roster, the roster's real. File says astronaut, active. I'll bill them when I'm back.

Peg looks at him a long moment. Then she takes the empty envelope, folds it once, and drops it in the stove kindling.

PEG

Supper's on in twenty.

CUT TO:

INT. FEDERAL FIELD OFFICE - NIGHT

Pell at his desk, late. His phone buzzes: a forwarded photo, grainy, time-stamped 1:14 AM — box trucks backed up to the Tri-County Auction Barn, loading doors lit.

Pell looks at it a long time. Then he prints it, pins it to a cork board, and picks up the phone.

EXT. GUNNY'S PORCH, SOUTH CAROLINA - NIGHT

Frogs. A police scanner murmurs on the TV tray, county traffic, numbers and street names.

Gunny sets down his sweet tea, leans to the morse key, and sends: two clicks. A pause. Two clicks.

EXT. COUNTY ROAD, NEBRASKA - NIGHT

Hay trucks — three of them, loaded high and tarped — pull out of the auction barn's back gate, running lights only, and spread out onto three different section roads.

EXT. TRI-COUNTY AUCTION BARN - DAWN

Four black SUVs and a box van of INSPECTORS in wind-breakers roll up the gravel. Pell, tablet in hand, motions: roll the doors.

The doors roll.

INT. TRI-COUNTY AUCTION BARN - CONTINUOUS

A carousel.

Dismantled across the whole floor — carved horses in ranks on padded trestles, brass poles in racks, a ring of men with brushes and gold leaf and coffee. Two hundred of them, easy. The gantry crane holds a palomino mid-air on soft slings.

A banner across the back wall: CUSTER COUNTY FAIR CENTENNIAL — CAROUSEL RESTORATION PROJECT. VOLUNTEERS WELCOME.

An AM radio plays farm futures. Nobody stops working.

Pell walks in slow. An inspector behind him lifts a tarp: horse legs, numbered with masking tape. Another checks the scale pit: swept concrete, a shop-vac parked in it.

A PAINTER, 60s, gold leaf on his knuckles, looks up from a horse's bridle.

PAINTER

You want a brush, friend? We're behind.

Pell doesn't answer. He walks the ranks of horses, taps one on the rump, reads the job board: a hauling schedule, handwritten, pinned next to feed-store receipts and a fair-committee letterhead.

He checks the photo on his tablet against the loading doors. Same doors. He looks at the crane. At the swept pit. At two hundred men painting.

PELL

(reading the
banner, flat)
"Volunteers welcome."

He stands in the middle of it a moment, tablet hanging from his hand.

PELL

Two hundred volunteers. On a Tuesday.

PAINTER

County pays for the gold leaf.

Pell looks at him. The Painter holds his eye, friendly, brush loaded and waiting.

Pell turns and walks out. The inspectors trail him. The doors roll shut behind them, and the barn holds still one beat — brushes up, nobody moving —

Then the AM radio changes to a ballgame, and the brushes come back down.

EXT. COUNTY ROAD - MORNING

The federal convoy heads back down the two-lane. It passes, coming the other way, a hay truck loaded high and tarped, then a second, then, a mile on, a third.

At the wheel of the third, cap low, arm out the window: TITO. A whip antenna bolted to the fender ticks in the wind.

The convoy doesn't slow. The hay rolls on.

CUT TO:

INT. DAWES BARN - NIGHT

Cricket packs a canvas kit bag on the workbench, item by item off a handwritten list: logbook, slide rule, a zippo, a folded photograph he doesn't look at.

Headlights swing across the wall. A truck door. Then DANNY in the barn doorway, keys still in his hand.

He looks at the simulator. At the orange SCRAP stencil. At the kit bag.

DANNY

I know what's in the barn, Dad.
I've known a year. I figured you'd
tell me when it mattered.

Cricket zips the bag halfway and stops.

DANNY

I'm not going to say any of the
things. About your age, or the
law, or Mom. You'd just stand
there and let me finish.

CRICKET

I would.

Danny looks at the logbook shelf — the fifty years of it —
and back at his father. Whatever he came to say next, he
doesn't say it.

DANNY

You need a driver?

CRICKET

Thursday. Four a.m. Dress like a
farmer.

DANNY

I am a farmer.

He goes. Cricket zips the bag the rest of the way.

INT. DAWES FARMHOUSE, BEDROOM - NIGHT

The kit bag open on the bed. Peg repacks it — not
differently, better. Rolls each item tight, wedges them
square.

PEG

You'll want the—

CRICKET

It's in there.

PEG

And the spare glasses.

CRICKET

Front pocket.

She holds up two pairs of socks.

PEG

Take the good ones. Not the gray,
they've quit.

She swaps them. Presses the lid of the bag flat with both hands, testing the pack of it.

LATER

The house dark. In the sewing room, one lamp. Peg at the Singer, the kit bag's canvas lid under the needle. She sews something small inside the underside of the flap – three sides, a pocket's worth of stitches – snips the thread, and smooths the canvas down flat so that nothing shows at all.

INT. ALVAREZ KITCHEN, EAST LOS ANGELES - NIGHT

A small kitchen, saints on the wall, a Singer older than NASA on its own table by the window.

LITA, 80s, and Tito stand on opposite sides of the kitchen table. Between them, spread the table's whole length: a flag. Hand-sewn. The field of stars runs one star past even – fifty-one.

They fold it together. Lengthwise. Lengthwise again. Then Lita starts the triangle folds from her end, tight and sharp, turning the colors over and over into themselves while Tito keeps the tension, and neither of them says one word.

The last fold tucks. A triangle of stars, packed tight.

Lita holds it a moment. Then she takes a small SAINT CHRISTOPHER medal on a pin from her apron pocket and pins it deep inside the last fold, where it will touch nothing but flag.

She puts the triangle in Tito's hands.

He kisses her forehead. Takes his cap off the chair, and goes. Through the window, under the streetlight, he sets the triangle on the truck seat with both hands.

Lita sits back down at the Singer and turns off the lamp.

CUT TO:

EXT. FRONTIER AEROSPACE, MAIN GATE - PRE-DAWN

4:00 AM by the guard shack clock. A farm truck rolls up to the contractor lane. DANNY at the wheel, seed cap. In the bed and cab: four men in gray coveralls — CRICKET, DUTCH, STITCH, GUNNY — with lunch coolers and a laminated work order.

The GATE GUARD scans the order: VALLEY SALVAGE & SURPLUS — ARCHIVAL UNIT FINAL SERVICING, BAY 1. Four names that aren't theirs.

GATE GUARD

Y'all know where you're going?

GUNNY

Son, we were servicing this bay before your daddy made the varsity.

The guard waves them through. Danny eases the truck in, knuckles white on the wheel, eyes forward.

INT. FRONTIER AEROSPACE, CARGO INTEGRATION HALL - PRE-DAWN

The six crates in their cradles. Pell, early, stands at LOT F peeling his own impound sticker while MACK holds out a document.

PELL

Attachment E-6. Notarized.
Backdated to March, I notice.

MACK

Filed in March. Copied slow.

PELL

Everything about you people is slow.

He initials the release, unhappy about it, and walks the row one last time — a long look down the stenciled flanks — then off toward the observation mezzanine.

THE SERVICING

The four "contractors" work the crates with purge carts and torque wrenches — competent, unhurried, invisible. Joss's dock crew moves around them, seeing nothing.

One by one, unhurried, each old man steps up on a cart, into a crate, and lies back into the molded couch.

Cricket is last. He sets his kit bag between his knees, looks up at Joss standing over him with the lid hoist — and past him, at the hall's high steel, the cranes, the morning light coming up the windows.

CRICKET

Tuesday net's at nineteen hundred,
your frequency card's taped under
the console. Don't improvise.

JOSS

Copy. No improvising.

CRICKET

And Joss. Thank your dad for the
radio.

Joss looks at him a second.

JOSS

Fly good, old man.

The lid comes down. Torque gun, eight bolts, a hiss as the purge line seats.

Joss raps the lid: knock-knock — pause — knock-knock.

From inside, muffled and exact: knock-knock — knock-knock.

He moves down the line. Raps LOT B. Answer. LOT C. Answer. LOT D. Answer. Four crates, four heartbeats.

At LOT E, Tito — contractor coveralls, cap backwards — sets a canvas-wrapped triangle into a padded corner mount, checks it twice with two knuckles, and seals the lid on the rest of the gear: tarped shapes, latched cases, gear.

THE RANDOM CHECK

A DOCKWORKER, 50s, Frontier badge, twenty-year lanyard tape on the clip, works the pre-stack checklist crate to crate. Torque seals. Purge pressure. Latch flags.

At LOT D, the checklist stops him: one latch flag showing amber. Procedure. He unslings his wrench, breaks the inspection latch, and lifts the service panel.

Inside, packed in the molded couch, kit bag between his knees, eyes open: CRICKET DAWES, looking straight up at him.

One second. Two. Three.

The Dockworker looks at the manifest on his clipboard. At the inspection tag in the holder: INSPECTED - J. PELL. At the old man in the crate, who does not blink.

The Dockworker resets the latch. Seats the panel. Signs the line.

INSERT: the checklist, block letters: LOT D - ALL CLEAR.

He moves to LOT E without looking back.

THE STACK

The transporter takes the crates out the high door into the dawn, six in a row, stencils catching the light: OLD IDEAS. OLD CULTURE. OLD CUSTOMS. OLD HABITS. SUPPLEMENTARY CONTAINMENT. SUPPLEMENTARY CONTAINMENT.

Mack and Joss watch from the dock edge. Mack signs the contractor crew OUT - four names, one pen, no one watching.

JOSS

Net's quiet. Two clicks if it stays that way.

MACK

Go home. Sleep.

Joss almost smiles. Doesn't manage it. The crates ride away toward the stacking cell, small against the building, then smaller.

CUT TO:

EXT. FRONTIER LAUNCH COMPLEX, PAD 1 - NIGHT

The rocket stands in its own light, primer-white flank blank where the flag was. Vapor bleeds off the stages and

rolls down the hull.

INT. CARGO BAY, CRATE D - NIGHT

Blackness. Then a small amber bus light steadies, and there is Cricket's face by its glow, flat on his back in the molded couch, kit bag between his knees.

Through the structure: pumps starting somewhere far below, a hum climbing through the frame into his shoulder blades.

He puts one hand flat on the lid above his face.

INT. KENNEDY BALLROOM, WASHINGTON - NIGHT

Chandeliers and a thousand guests. UNITY EVE in living flowers across the stage. At center, a scale model of the Harmony Banner under glass.

Marwani works the room in black tie, handshake to handshake. On a screen the size of a barn door: the live pad feed.

INT. FRONTIER MISSION CONTROL - NIGHT

Rows of consoles. In a glassed VIP row, VESS, standing, arms folded. Beside her, PELL with a commemorative program.

At a podium off the floor, HALE reads to a camera, voice level and dead.

HALE

Frontier is honored to carry the
Lunar Heritage Neutralization
Accord to flight. Tonight belongs
to the community of nations.

He steps away from the podium before the light on the camera is off.

EXT. PAD 1, CREW ACCESS ARM - NIGHT

The HARMONY CREW crosses in white suits, helmets under arms: CMDR. BRANDT, silver at the temples; MAJ. LINDQVIST;

OBSERVER SHEN, a head shorter, mission patch of the 44-nation banner.

At the hatch, Brandt pauses. Looks up the whole height of the stack, a long way, to where the vapor curls off into the dark. Then he goes in.

INT. ROY'S DINER - NIGHT

Full house, quiet. Every face turned to the TV: the pad, the clock. Earlene has stopped pretending to wipe anything.

BUCK

There she goes in a minute. Ours.
Whatever's riding her.

Nobody answers him. The Cook comes out of the kitchen and stands with his towel over his shoulder.

INT. KENNEDY BALLROOM - NIGHT

Marwani takes the stage, flute in hand. The room hushes. On the barn-door screen behind him, the countdown clock walks down through ninety seconds.

MARWANI

Tonight a rocket rises with no
flag on its side. Think of that.
Not conquest. Not pride. Repair. A
machine built by the old America,
flying the first errand of the new
one.

INT. CARGO BAY, CRATE D - NIGHT

The hum has become a shudder. Dust ticks off the lid seam in the amber light. Cricket's breathing stays even, eyes open.

MARWANI (V.O.)

(over the ballroom
PA, distant)

— so raise a glass, to a healed
sky —

INT. FRONTIER MISSION CONTROL - NIGHT

LAUNCH DIRECTOR (O.S.)
- three. Two. One.

EXT. PAD 1 - NIGHT

Ignition. The night goes orange for a mile. The rocket climbs off the pad on a column of fire, slow, then not slow.

INT. KENNEDY BALLROOM - NIGHT

The screen floods the ballroom with launch light. A thousand flutes tip together. Applause swells over the engine roar in the feed.

INT. CARGO BAY, CRATE D - LAUNCH

Weight. The couch takes Cricket deep into its molding, jaw pulled back, hand still flat on the lid. The amber light dims under the load - holds - comes back.

INT. ROY'S DINER - NIGHT

The rocket climbs on the TV. The diner watches it go, faces lit by the screen. Wade the deputy, at the counter in civvies, has his hat off, held against his chest.

EXT. SPACE - LATER

Engine cutoff. The roar stops all at once. The ship coasts, sunrise crawling up the curve of the Earth below, the white hull going gold along one edge.

INT. CARGO BAY - CONTINUOUS

Dark and still. Cricket's kit bag floats up off his knees to the end of its lanyard and hangs there, drifting.

A sound in the dark bay. Two knocks. Pause. Two knocks.

From another crate: two knocks - two knocks.

A third crate answers. Then a fourth.

The bay hangs quiet, four amber lights burning in four sealed boxes, the Earth turning gold in the one small window across the bay.

CUT TO:

INT. HARMONY ONE, CARGO BAY - SHIP'S NIGHT

The bay dark except for panel standby glow. Six crates ranked and strapped, four amber lights showing at their vent slits. Beyond the one small window, the Earth, whole, the size of a dinner plate and shrinking.

A knock sequence taps out of crate B - long-short rhythms, patient.

INT. CRATE C - CONTINUOUS

Dutch, amber-lit, a pocket notebook against his knee. He pencils letters as the knocks land, one at a time:

INSERT - THE NOTEBOOK: "STITCH ASKS IF ANYONE ELSE'S HOTEL HAS ROOM SERVICE."

Dutch reaches up without looking and knocks his reply on the crate wall, slow and even.

INSERT - THE NOTEBOOK, next line: "TOLD HIM. TAKE IT UP WITH THE SPEC AUTHOR."

INT. HARMONY ONE, CARGO BAY - LATER

The service rotation. Crate A's panel swings open from inside, slow, and GUNNY floats out in thermal underwear and socks, a small kit bag tethered to his wrist.

He works crate to crate in the dark, unhurried: swaps a scrubber cartridge through Crate B's service port. Checks Crate C's purge gauge with a penlight hooded in his fist.

At Crate D, he unclips a steel thermos from his kit, opens the vent hatch, and passes it through.

CRICKET (O.S.)
(a whisper, from
inside)
Obliged.

Gunny closes the hatch to a half-inch. Turns for his own crate —

The bay door seal hisses. Light spills in.

Gunny goes flat behind Crate F, one hand on a strap, socks floating.

MAJ. LINDQVIST drifts in with a flashlight, coveralls sleeves rolled, running a routine sweep. The beam walks down the stencils: OLD IDEAS. OLD CULTURE. OLD CUSTOMS. The beam crosses the half-open vent hatch on Crate D.

Lindqvist frowns at it, pushes the hatch flush with one finger until it clicks, checks nothing else, and drifts back out. The door seals.

Dark again. Gunny lets go of the strap.

He crosses to the small window instead of his crate. Holds the frame with both hands.

Out there: the Moon, filling a third of the glass, gray and coming.

Gunny looks at it a long time. Then he pushes off, floats back into Crate A, and pulls the panel shut behind him. The amber lights burn in the dark.

CUT TO:

INT. HARMONY ONE, CARGO BAY - SHIP'S DAY

Work lights on. OBSERVER SHEN floats the crate line alone, tablet tethered to his wrist, stylus in hand. Cargo audit: serial by serial, seal by seal.

He reads Crate A's stencil — OLD IDEAS — and enters the serial. The purge gauge: nominal. He moves down the line.

OLD CULTURE. Serial. Gauge. Entry.

OLD CUSTOMS. Serial. Gauge. Entry.

At OLD HABITS — Crate D — he stops.

He holds still, head tilted a few degrees.

INT. CRATE D - CONTINUOUS

Cricket, flat in the amber glow. A shadow lies across his vent slit and does not move.

He stops breathing. Not slowly – all at once, mid-breath, held.

INT. HARMONY ONE, CARGO BAY - CONTINUOUS

Shen drifts closer to the crate. Reads the inspection tag: INSPECTED – J. PELL. Reads the serial. Checks the gauge – nominal, steady.

Then he takes off one glove, wedges it under his arm, and lays his bare palm flat on the crate's skin.

He leaves it there.

INT. CRATE D - CONTINUOUS

Cricket, breath held, eyes on the lid an inch above his face. The only sound in here is his own heart, loud, and getting louder.

INT. HARMONY ONE, CARGO BAY - CONTINUOUS

Shen's palm on the metal. His face gives nothing. Five seconds. Eight.

Behind him, the bay door: CMDR. BRANDT drifts halfway in.

BRANDT

Shen. Burn prep. Straps in twenty.

Shen doesn't startle. He lifts his palm from the crate, works his glove back on, and makes an entry on the tablet.

INSERT – THE TABLET: LOT D – SEALS INTACT. PURGE NOMINAL. NO ANOMALY.

He follows Brandt out. The lights bank down to standby. The door seals.

INT. CRATE D - CONTINUOUS

Cricket lets the breath go, slow, through his teeth.

A moment. Then, from Crate C, very soft through the walls:
two knocks.

Cricket reaches up and answers: two knocks.

The amber light burns. Nothing else moves.

CUT TO:

EXT. DAWES FARM, PORCH - DAY

A single black SUV in the drive - one, this time, and washed. A young WHITE HOUSE AIDE in a good coat stands at the bottom of the porch steps, holding a phone out flat on his upturned palm.

On the porch: PEG, arms crossed. DANNY beside her, sleeves rolled.

MARWANI (V.O.)

(from the phone,
warm)

Mrs. Dawes. I hope I find you
well. Is the Commander home?

PEG

He's out.

MARWANI (V.O.)

Of course. Mrs. Dawes, the country
is about to share a difficult,
beautiful day, and the President -
I - would rather share it whole
than divided. There are men, I'm
told, for whom the past fifty
years were a wound. Your husband
trained for something that was
taken from him. I cannot give him
back the years. But I can give him
the rest.

Peg says nothing. The aide's arm is getting tired.

MARWANI (V.O.)

The pension, made whole - that's
done, as a gesture. The record,
amended: Apollo Eighteen entered
into the rolls with his name on
the crew. Flown status, conferred

by executive order — the title,
the wings, the history. All of it,
Mrs. Dawes. On one condition.
Unity Day passes undisturbed — and
your husband watches it at home.
On his porch. Visibly. Where the
country can see a great American
at peace with a new world.

Wind in the shelterbelt. Peg looks at the phone on the
young man's palm.

PEG

I'll pass it along if he phones.

MARWANI (V.O.)

Mrs. Dawes—

PEG

You have a good day now.

She goes inside. The screen door claps. Danny stays a beat
longer, looking at the aide, then follows her in. The aide
is left holding his own phone out to a farmhouse.

EXT. RIDGE ROAD, NEBRASKA - NIGHT

Joss's truck on a high section road, tailgate down, a wire
antenna run from a mast clamp to a fencepost. Joss works a
morse key by red flashlight, a paper of cipher groups
taped to the tailgate. Danny leans on the fender, watching
the sky.

JOSS

Pass is six minutes. It's enough.

He keys. Stops. Listens to the hiss.

INT. CRATE D - NIGHT (LOW EARTH ORBIT)

The amber light. Morse, thin and far, ticking in Cricket's
earpiece. He copies letters onto his pad, steady, no
expression.

The pad fills: PENSION WHOLE. RECORD AMENDED. FLOWN
STATUS. EXEC ORDER. CONDITION: HOME ON PORCH UNITY DAY.
VISIBLE.

Cricket looks at the word VISIBLE a moment.

He rests his knuckle twice on the crate wall - pause - twice. From crate C, twice - twice back. From B. From A.

Then he takes the key wired at his hip and sends, short and even.

EXT. RIDGE ROAD - CONTINUOUS

Joss copies onto the tailgate paper, letter by letter, lips moving. Then he stops keying back. Reads it. Reads it again.

DANNY

What's he say?

JOSS

(reading)

"Tell him: you can't give back
what you never had."

Danny looks at the paper. At the sky.

JOSS

There's more.

Joss's pencil finishes the last group.

JOSS

"Dawes out."

Overhead, among all the fixed stars, one moving point of light crosses the dark, west to east, steady.

They watch it go all the way to the horizon.

CUT TO:

INT. FRONTIER MISSION CONTROL - NIGHT

The floor quiet and full. On the main screen, the ship's track curls away from the Earth line toward a drawn gray circle.

FLIGHT DIRECTOR

Flight controllers, go no-go for
trans-lunar injection. Guidance.

CONTROLLER (O.S.)

Go.

FLIGHT DIRECTOR

Propulsion.

CONTROLLER #2 (O.S.): Go.

FLIGHT DIRECTOR

Harmony One, you are go for TLI.

In the glass VIP row, Vess stands alone at the rail.
Behind her, Pell works through a commemorative program
with a highlighter.

BRANDT (V.O.)

(on the loop)

Copy. Go for TLI.

INT. HARMONY ONE, CARGO BAY - CONTINUOUS

The bay in standby glow. Four amber lights at four vent
slits.

A clunk through the structure. Then the push — long,
smooth, gathering — straps creaking taut against the
crates.

INT. CRATE D - CONTINUOUS

Cricket pressed back into the couch, the amber light
steady, his hand flat on the lid. The burn goes on. And
on.

Then: cutoff. Weightless again. The kit bag floats up to
the end of its lanyard.

INT. CRATE C - CONTINUOUS

Dutch, pencil out, runs figures in the notebook margin —
velocity, a time, an arc — and boxes the result, twice.

INSERT — THE NOTEBOOK: BURN NOMINAL. COAST 62 HRS. NO
ABORT MODES REMAIN.

He looks at the boxed line a moment. Then he knocks on his
crate wall: two — two.

Two - two, from D. Two - two, from B. Two - two, from A.

INT. FRONTIER MISSION CONTROL - CONTINUOUS

The track on the main screen bends out of Earth's neighborhood for good. Applause on the floor, brief and professional.

Vess watches the line go. She lets go of the rail, one finger at a time.

FLIGHT DIRECTOR
Trajectory nominal. Sixty-two
hours to lunar orbit insertion,
gentlemen. Get some sleep.

Pell caps his highlighter.

PELL
Well. Nothing stopping it now.

Vess doesn't answer him.

CUT TO:

END OF ACT TWO

INT. FRONTIER MISSION CONTROL - DAY

Every console manned, every screen the same: the gray surface coming up under the lander's camera, dust beginning to streak.

BRANDT (V.O.)
(on the loop)
Two hundred feet. Down at three.
Picking up some dust.

INT. ROY'S DINER - CONTINUOUS

Standing room only. The TV huge in the corner. Nobody eats.

INT. JOSS'S TRUCK, RIDGE ROAD - CONTINUOUS

Joss and Danny shoulder to shoulder in the cab, a phone propped on the dash streaming the feed, the ham rig silent beside it.

BRANDT (V.O.)
(on the phone,
compressed)
Fifty feet. Forty. Contact light –
engine stop.

The dust settles on every screen in America. HARMONY ONE stands on the Sea of Tranquility, primer-white, flagless.

The diner watches, still. Somebody's coffee goes cold untouched.

EXT. SEA OF TRANQUILITY - LUNAR DAY

Silence and glare. The lander's shadow long across the regolith.

The crew works the base-station deployment: BRANDT and LINDQVIST wrestling a solar array true, SHEN anchoring a comms mast, all three helmet-cams feeding Earth. A camera boom pans slow across the site for the broadcast.

Behind the lander, in its blind spot, the cargo ramp is down.

Four crates stand open on the ramp, lids back, couches empty.

Four suited figures move in the lander's shadow – suits fifty years old, patched and re-hosed, the NASA meatball bright on every chest. On one wrist cuff, a small brass museum tag turns on its wire.

They cross-load gear from crates E and F onto the BACKUP ROVER – tarped bundles, latched cases, a long soft-sided sleeve strapped diagonal. Practiced. Unhurried. Not one wasted move.

The last man aboard is the tallest. He settles into the rover's rear rack seat, raps the fender twice – pause – twice.

The rover pulls away from the lander in a slow arc, out of the shadow, into the sun, four men and their freight, tire

tracks unspooling behind it across ground no one has touched in fifty years.

It gets small against the gray. Then it drops behind a rise and is gone.

At the base station, Brandt straightens up from the array and turns, helmet glare white.

BRANDT
(on the loop)
Base station nominal. Harmony One,
beginning retrieval operations at
first light tomorrow, per the
program.

Behind him, far off over the rise, a thin dust hangs a moment, and settles.

CUT TO:

EXT. SURVEYOR CRATER, APOLLO 12 SITE - LUNAR DAY

The prime rover crests a low ridge, camera boom high, three suits aboard. Below: the Apollo 12 descent stage, gold foil still bright, experiment packages ranked where men left them in 1969.

LINDQVIST
(reading from a cue
card clipped to his
cuff)
"We arrive as guests of history,
to relieve it of its oldest burden
_"

He stops reading.

Where the flag should stand: a socket hole in the gray. Around it, bootprints - crisp, recent, not theirs. And leading in and out of the site, wheel tracks.

BRANDT
Harmony, Site One. The artifact
is... not present.

INT. FRONTIER MISSION CONTROL - CONTINUOUS

Rows of faces, nobody moving. On the main screen, the empty socket hole, full screen.

FLIGHT DIRECTOR

Say again, Harmony One?

BRANDT (V.O.)

The flag is gone. The site is otherwise intact. We observe recent surface activity. Bootprints. Vehicle tracks.

INT. UNITY DAY PAVILION, WASHINGTON - CONTINUOUS

A daytime stage dressed in harmony blue, schoolchildren holding little Harmony Banners. Marwani mid-remarks at a podium, teleprompter rolling. Behind him, on the giant screen: the live feed cuts to a graphic — PLEASE STAND BY: UNITY DAY.

An AIDE climbs the stage steps and whispers. Marwani keeps smiling at the children while he listens.

INT. JOSS'S TRUCK - CONTINUOUS

The phone on the dash: a jittery re-stream of the raw feed, chat scrolling too fast to read.

JOSS

They can't cut the raw loop. It relays through nine countries.

DANNY

Where are the flags, Joss?

Joss looks at the ham rig. Says nothing. Two clicks come out of it, soft. Then two more.

EXT. FRA MAURO, APOLLO 14 SITE - LATER

The rover parked. Three suits standing at another socket hole, another ring of prints, the same wheel tracks arriving and leaving.

Lindqvist holds his cue card, doesn't read it.

ON A STREAMER'S FEED (INSET)

A man in a gaming chair, veins out.

STREAMER

There were NEVER any flags! Fifty
years of soundstage! They're on
the Moon looking for PROPS,
people! WAKE UP!

INT. ROY'S DINER - CONTINUOUS

The TV: the socket hole again. Buck turns his cup a
quarter turn.

BUCK

Somebody took 'em.

EARLENE

Took 'em where, Buck? It's the
Moon.

Buck drinks his coffee. On his face, slowly, the beginning
of a smile.

EXT. FRA MAURO - CONTINUOUS

Brandt stands over the wheel tracks. Follows them with his
visor to where they run off northwest, dead straight, out
of sight.

He switches to the private crew loop. Click.

SHEN

(on the private
loop)

Commander. The possibility must be
raised. If the artifacts were
never — if the landings themselves
were—

BRANDT

Don't.

Silence on the loop. Shen looks at the bootprints — fifty
years of undisturbed prints around the socket, and the new
ones laid over them, crisp-edged, fresh.

BRANDT

Mount up. Last site on the
program.

LINDQVIST
Tranquility Base.

Brandt takes one more look northwest along the wheel
tracks. Dead straight. Toward Tranquility.

BRANDT
Whoever they are, they're not
hiding their driving.

CUT TO:

EXT. APPROACH TO TRANQUILITY BASE - LUNAR DAY

The prime rover parked at the foot of a long, low rise.
The three Harmony astronauts climb it on foot, single
file, the camera boom and their helmet-cams feeding Earth.

BRANDT
(on the loop)
Harmony, on foot, one hundred
meters from Tranquility Base
perimeter. Site should be visual
past this rise.

INT. FRONTIER MISSION CONTROL - CONTINUOUS

Every screen: the bobbing helmet-cam view, gray ground,
black sky, the rise coming up.

The chest-mounted camera clears the rise before any man's
helmet does.

On the main screen, over the lip of ground: COLOR.

A CONTROLLER stands up so fast his headset cord snaps
taut. Nobody says anything. The image steadies as Brandt
keeps climbing, seeing nothing yet but his own boots.

FULL FRAME, TO EARTH:

Six American flags. Vibrant — red, white, blue against the
black — five of them planted in a wide ring around the low
hill of Tranquility Base, and at the center, on the

original pole, raised again where it fell in 1969: the first one.

Inside the ring: four webbed aluminum lawn chairs. A squat steel grill on legs, hoses run to a bottle, a curl of vapor flashing off its seams. A card table. On the card table, a cooler.

And four old men in fifty-year-old suits, three seated, one standing at the grill with a long spatula, all facing the rise.

Behind the party, stood on end in a row, side by side: four emptied crates, stenciled faces out -

OLD IDEAS. OLD CULTURE. OLD CUSTOMS. OLD HABITS.

Planted beside the grill, smaller than the six, on a workshop flagpole: a hand-sewn flag with one star too many.

A tripod stands off to the side - their own camera, a red light on it, its feed already on Earth's internet.

INT. ROY'S DINER - CONTINUOUS

The TV. The ring of flags. The lawn chairs.

Buck is on his feet. So is everybody.

BUCK

There they are.

INT. UNITY DAY PAVILION - CONTINUOUS

Marwani, mid-sentence, feels the crowd's eyes go past him. He turns. The screen behind him holds the ring of flags, forty feet tall.

The schoolchildren, front row, see flags and lawn chairs and a cookout.

They cheer.

INT. FRONTIER TRAINING ROOM (WATCH PARTY) - CONTINUOUS

Folding chairs, sheet cake. The FACILITATOR from Module 7 stands frozen with a paper plate, reading her own slide off the crate lids.

ON A NEWS PANEL (INSET)

A PANELIST freezes mid-sentence, ear to his earpiece.

PANELIST

(on TV)

— I'm being told those suits — the suits are the Apollo artifacts Frontier donated to the heritage program last spring. They're wearing the museum pieces.

ON A STREAMER'S FEED (INSET)

The streamer, mid-rant, stops. His jaw works. Dead air, chat avalanching.

EXT. TRAM STOP, WARSAW - NIGHT

Strangers packed around one phone. The ring of flags glows off their faces. Somebody starts to clap. Others join. It spreads down the platform.

EXT. TRANQUILITY BASE - CONTINUOUS

Brandt's eyes finally clear the rise. He stops walking. Lindqvist stops behind him. Shen stops last.

The three of them stand on the lip of the ground, looking down at the most illegal Fourth of July in human history.

At the grill, the tall suited figure sees them, straightens up, and raises the spatula — unhurried, all the way up.

Hold on that.

CUT TO:

EXT. TRANQUILITY BASE - LUNAR DAY

Brandt comes down the rise slow, hands visible, Lindqvist and Shen behind him. The ring of flags stands around them,

colors hard in the sun. The tripod camera's red light burns.

Brandt stops ten meters out. Keys his radio.

BRANDT
Switching to channel two. Let's
talk privately, gentlemen.

The old man at the grill doesn't move. The one in the second chair - CRICKET, gray stubble behind the visor glass - keys the OPEN loop.

CRICKET
We'll talk right here. Whole
world's listening anyway.

INT. FRONTIER MISSION CONTROL - CONTINUOUS

The Flight Director looks at the loop status: OPEN. Every word going to Earth raw. Nobody moves to change it.

EXT. TRANQUILITY BASE - CONTINUOUS

Brandt looks back at his crew. Then walks closer. Reads the crate lids, left to right. Reads the small flag with too many stars. Reads the grill.

LINDQVIST
(blurting)
Where did you even COME from?

CRICKET
We came in the mail.

A beat.

BRANDT
(formal, for the
record)
This site is designated for
retrieval under the Lunar Heritage
Neutralization Accord. I am
required to ask who you are and by
what authority you interfere.

The old men look at each other. Cricket stands up out of his lawn chair, unhurried, and faces him.

CRICKET

We're the backup crew. NASA never processed us out. We're still on the roster, son. This is our mission.

STITCH

(from his chair,
not getting up)

This here's our camp. Pack the fuck off.

INT. WHITE HOUSE, COUNSEL'S OFFICE - CONTINUOUS

Four LAWYERS around a speakerphone, laptops open. One of them has a personnel file on screen: DAWES, E. - ASTRONAUT (ACTIVE). A fifty-year column of quarterly entries: \$0.00. \$0.00. \$0.00.

LAWYER #1: Tell me this is a database error.

LAWYER #2: It's been signed off every quarter since 1972, by career staff, under four statutes. And three months ago somebody reactivated the annuity - we did - which means this administration AFFIRMED the status-

LAWYER #1: So they're not trespassers.

LAWYER #2: They're federal personnel on their duty station. If that crew removes them on camera, the crew of a foreign-flagged mission will be laying hands on serving American officers. On live television. On the Fourth of July.

Silence around the speakerphone.

EXT. TRANQUILITY BASE - CONTINUOUS

Shen steps forward, past Brandt, toward the nearest flag in the ring.

All four old men come out of their chairs at once - no signal given, none needed - and stand between him and the colors.

Shen stops.

The one from the grill - GUNNY, tallest, spatula still in hand - looks down at him through the visor glass a long moment. Then points the spatula, once, back at the Harmony rover.

Nobody on the open loop says anything. Nobody moves.

BRANDT
(on the loop, eyes
on the old men)
Harmony copies. Control - Harmony
requests instructions.

The old men sit back down, one at a time, Cricket last.
Gunny goes back to the grill and flips what's on it.

CUT TO:

INT. FRONTIER MISSION CONTROL - CONTINUOUS

The Flight Director stands at his console, headset half-off, looking at a message on his screen: WASHINGTON DIRECTS: PROCEED WITH RETRIEVAL PER ACCORD SCHEDULE. ACKNOWLEDGE.

He looks at it a long moment. Then he takes the headset all the way off and sets it on the console.

A new voice comes onto the loop anyway - accented, smooth, piped in from somewhere that is not this room.

ACCORD COORDINATOR (V.O.)
Harmony One, this is Accord
Coordination, Geneva. You are
directed to proceed with retrieval
of all six artifacts. Immediately,
please.

EXT. TRANQUILITY BASE - CONTINUOUS

Brandt stands in the ring of flags. He looks at the old men in their lawn chairs. At the first flag, center, on its 1969 pole.

BRANDT
(quietly, on the
loop)
Copy, Geneva.

He walks to the nearest flag in the ring. Plants his boots. And reaches for the staff.

Four old men come out of four lawn chairs and step between him and the colors in one motion — a line, shoulder to shoulder, visors level, Cricket at the center.

Brandt's glove stops a foot short. He is looking at a color guard.

Gunny, at the end of the line, keys the open loop. His voice comes slow and even, to Brandt, and to every living room on Earth.

GUNNY

You want 'em? Come through us.

INT. ROY'S DINER - CONTINUOUS

Everybody is already standing. Buck's fist comes down on the counter, once —

BUCK

U-S-A!

— and the diner takes it up, coffee cups rattling.

DINER

USA! USA! USA!

INT. TRI-COUNTY AUCTION BARN - CONTINUOUS

The carousel crew around a paint-spattered radio, brushes down, two hundred voices pounding it out, gold leaf shaking off a horse's bridle.

EXT. HIGHWAY OVERPASS - CONTINUOUS

Pickup trucks parked fender to fender. Men drop a flag the size of a bedsheet over the rail into the wind above six lanes. Horns below, hundreds, leaning on it.

EXT. CUSTER COUNTY FAIRGROUNDS - CONTINUOUS

The Fourth of July fair, in full swing. At its center, gold leaf bright under the lights: the carousel, restored,

turning, packed with kids – and every grown-up around it on their feet, chanting at a phone screen somebody holds up.

INT. BROOKLYN LOFT, WATCH PARTY - CONTINUOUS

The UNITY DAY shirts crowd, forty of them, on their feet – half of them chanting USA, USA, caught up in it, before some remember themselves and stop, hands over mouths.

Some don't stop.

EXT. RIDGE ROAD - CONTINUOUS

Joss, truck door open, working the morse key fast. Danny beside him, hands on top of his head.

INT./EXT. TRANQUILITY BASE - CONTINUOUS

In Cricket's earpiece, thin and far, morse – three letters, over and over.

Behind the glass, Cricket swallows once.

Brandt lowers his arm. Steps back – one step.

SHEN

(private loop)

Commander. Your orders–

BRANDT

(private loop)

I know my orders.

He keys back to open.

BRANDT

Geneva, Harmony One. The site is... occupied by personnel asserting jurisdiction. Requesting political guidance.

Long static. On the card table, unhurried, Gunny deals four hands of cards.

CUT TO:

INT. ROY'S DINER - DAY

The TV: PRESIDENT MARWANI at the briefing-room podium, flags of forty-four nations pinned behind him.

MARWANI

(on TV)

This morning I directed Frontier Aerospace to restore mission control and end this provocation. Not because we fear four old men. Because the world deserves the day it was promised. The company's obligations are clear. So are the consequences of failing them.

He steps away from the podium without questions.

INT. FRONTIER AEROSPACE, PRESS ROOM - DAY

Live lights. Cameras banked three deep. HALE at the podium, a single prepared page in his hand. Off-stage, in the dark of the wings: VESS, arms folded, watching.

Hale flattens the page on the podium. Reads, in the dead voice.

HALE

"Frontier Aerospace condemns the unauthorized occupation of the Tranquility site, and will comply fully with federal direction to..."

He stops. Looks at the next line. The room waits, shutters clicking.

He folds the page in half. And in half again. And sets it down, squared to the podium's edge.

HALE

I can't read this one.

He looks straight into the bank of cameras. When he speaks again, the flatness is gone.

HALE

Somebody used my rocket to do the finest thing an American has done

in fifty years. You want somebody
to punish for that? You want to
nationalize me? Go. Fuck.
Yourself.

Flashes. Bedlam. Aides somewhere off-camera shouting the
feed down, and failing, because the feed is his.

Hale steps off the podium. A REPORTER stands into his
path, recorder out.

REPORTER
Mr. Hale — the President is saying
you've betrayed the community of—

HALE
(walking, not
turning)
Tell the commie he can eat shit.

He passes Vess in the wings. Stops. The two of them look
at each other, one beat, two.

He keeps walking. She watches him go. The corner of her
mouth moves.

INT. ROY'S DINER - CONTINUOUS

Frozen. Then BUCK laughs — one short bark — and slaps the
counter.

The COOK looks at the carbon meter on his gas line. Then
he turns the flat-top burners up, all the way, all of
them.

INT. FRONTIER AEROSPACE, LOBBY - DUSK

Doors bang open. PELL crosses the marble at speed with two
FEDERAL MARSHALS, tablet under his arm, lanyard swinging.

PELL
(to the desk, not
stopping)
Where is the override room, and
where is Mira Vess?

CUT TO:

INT. FRONTIER AEROSPACE, VESS'S OFFICE - NIGHT

Corner office, lights low, the launch complex out the glass. VESS stands behind her desk. On the desk: one folder, squared to the blotter.

The door opens. PELL, marshals behind him.

VESS

They wait in the hall.

PELL

They're federal marshals.

Vess says nothing. She waits.

Pell looks at her. Then nods the marshals back. The door clicks.

PELL

Ms. Vess. I am here for the mission override, and I am past asking nicely.

VESS

There is no override. The ship answers its crew. You built the compliance regime, Administrator — nothing at this company moves without a signature. You know that better than anyone.

She opens the folder. Takes out the first page. Lays it in front of him, turned to face him.

VESS

The integration re-weigh. Four anomalous mass readings, invalidated by calibration drift, accepted into the federal record. Countersigned.

His own signature, at the bottom.

VESS

Attachment E-6, releasing containment unit F from impound. Initialed.

The second page goes down. His initials.

VESS
Inspection certification,
containment unit D. Personally
executed.

The carbon of the orange tag: INSPECTED — J. PELL. She
lays a fourth page beside it — the re-weigh acceptance,
unit D line highlighted.

VESS
Twice.

Pell looks down at the pages. At his own name, four times,
in his own hand.

PELL
You scheduled my inspections.

She takes out the last page and lays it down: a printed
calendar memo. RANDOM COMPLIANCE RE-WEIGH — WINDOW
PROPOSED PER M. VESS OFFICE.

PELL
(quiet)
Random means random.

VESS
It does.

Pell stares at the pages. His hand moves toward them,
stops.

PELL
The scale tech. Yours?

Vess looks at him and says nothing at all.

PELL
You understand what you've — if I
take this public, you go to
prison.

VESS
With every document bearing your
signature, Administrator.

She comes around the desk, past him, to the door, and
stops with her hand on it.

VESS

You wanted the company to
cooperate. The company cooperated.
The country didn't.

She opens the door and walks out through the marshals,
unhurried, down the hall, gone.

Pell stands alone in her office, in front of the desk, the
pages lined up facing the empty chair.

After a moment, he sits down in front of them, in the
visitor's chair, and doesn't touch anything.

CUT TO:

INT. FRONTIER AEROSPACE, HALE'S OFFICE - NIGHT

Dark. The launch complex lit below the glass. Hale at the
desk, tie gone, the phone in his hand.

He types two words. Looks at them.

INSERT — THE PHONE: Look up.

He posts it, and sets the phone face down on the desk.

INT. ROY'S DINER - NIGHT

The phone behind the register buzzes. Earlene reads it.
Shows the Cook.

EXT. DAWES FARMHOUSE - NIGHT

The yard dark. The porch light comes on.

Off. On. Off — on, on.

PEG on the porch in her house coat, hand on the switch,
working it: two — pause — two. Two — pause — two.

EXT. RIDGE ROAD - NIGHT

Joss's truck headlights answer across the dark section
land: two — two. Danny, standing in the bed, watches
farmhouse after farmhouse come alight down the valley —
porch lights snapping on, some steady, some flashing,
spreading fence line to fence line.

EXT. PIONEER FIELD, BALLPARK - NIGHT

Empty stands. The GROUNDSKEEPER at the breaker panel throws the light towers on - off - on, whole banks at a time, the field strobing under them.

EXT. AMERICA - NIGHT (AERIAL)

Suburb grids pulse. A skyline flickers block by block. Highways run bright with flashers. The dark country between cities fills with pinpoints, porch by porch, until there is no dark country.

EXT. TRANQUILITY BASE - CONTINUOUS

The card game. Stitch, holding his hand of cards, has looked up - past the flags, at the Earth hanging in the black.

STITCH

Y'all.

They look up. The four olds. Then Brandt. Then Lindqvist. Then Shen.

The night side of the Earth is flickering. Waves of light crawl across it - coastlines pulsing, whole seaboards going bright and dark and bright.

Seven visors tilt back, the Earth small and bright in every one of them.

Nobody says anything for a long time. The cards hang in Stitch's glove, forgotten.

At the grill, without looking away from the Earth, Gunny reaches over and turns down the burner.

CUT TO:

EXT. TRANQUILITY BASE - CONTINUOUS

The Earth still ripples with light. Gunny works the grill - opens the sealed press, and there they are, in rows, vapor flashing off them: burgers.

Brandt watches from three meters, and his voice arrives on the open loop, unguarded.

BRANDT
...is that a burger?

INT. FRONTIER MISSION CONTROL - CONTINUOUS

A beat of dead air on the floor. Then a controller snorts. Then the whole back row goes.

ON SCREENS AROUND THE WORLD

The clip replays instantly, captioned in forty languages. IS THAT A BURGER? crawls under the ring of flags on every network.

EXT. TRAM STOP, WARSAW - NIGHT

The platform crowd, bigger now, howls.

INT. GENEVA, ACCORD PRESS ROOM - DAY

The ACCORD COORDINATOR at a lectern, gray suit, grim.

ACCORD COORDINATOR
The retrieval program remains, in
the Accord's view, scheduled -

The press row laughs. Not politely. He looks down at his notes, and a minister seated behind him checks his phone and grins before he can stop himself.

INT. WHITE HOUSE, PRESS BRIEFING ROOM - DAY

The PRESS SECRETARY at the podium, gripping it.

PRESS SECRETARY
The President believes the
situation at the site has -
evolved -

A laugh from the back row. Then the middle rows. She stands in it, looking down at her briefing book.

EXT. TRANQUILITY BASE - CONTINUOUS

Brandt looks at the burgers a long moment. Then he keys the open loop, formal, every word chosen.

BRANDT

Geneva, Harmony One. Site survey complete. There is nothing at Tranquility to retrieve. There is a color guard, on station, under national colors. Harmony One stands down.

Static from Geneva. Nothing else.

Gunny loads a burger onto the long spatula and extends it across the three meters, steady.

Brandt looks at his crew. Lindqvist's glove comes up: go on.

Brandt takes the burger and holds it up beside his visor -- the enemy commander, the ring of flags, the flickering Earth behind him.

The tripod camera's red light burns. On every screen on Earth, the same frame.

Lindqvist accepts one too, laughing inside his helmet, silent behind glass.

Shen stands apart, arms folded. Gunny plates a burger anyway and sets it on the card table, in front of the empty fourth chair, facing him.

It sits there. Shen looks at it, and away.

INT. ROY'S DINER - NIGHT

The frame on the TV: Brandt and the burger. The Cook's flat-top is full edge to edge. He starts plating burgers nobody ordered, passing them down the counter, waving off every wallet that comes out.

Buck raises his coffee cup to the TV and holds it up a moment.

CUT TO:

EXT. TRANQUILITY BASE - LATER

The card table cleared. Off to the side, angled toward the black sky: a short rack of three mortar tubes, welded neat, cabled to a firing box on the card table.

The four olds stand in a loose line inside the ring of flags. Brandt and Lindqvist stand behind them. Shen stands apart, arms folded, but he stands.

Gunny takes a folded photocopy from his wrist pocket and opens it with both gloves. When he speaks, it is slower, and older.

GUNNY

John Adams. Wrote this to his wife, July of 1776, about this day.

He reads.

GUNNY

"It ought to be solemnized with pomp and parade. With shows, games, sports, guns, bells, bonfires and illuminations — from one end of this continent to the other. From this time forward. Forevermore."

He folds the paper and puts it away.

GUNNY

Two hundred and fifty years, and here we all are. One end of the continent to the other — and a little past it.

INT. TRI-COUNTY AUCTION BARN - CONTINUOUS

The carousel floor. Two hundred men, Joss, Danny, and TITO around the radio and a live feed. On the loop, Cricket's voice.

CRICKET (V.O.)

Tito Alvarez. You built the tubes. Count us down.

Tito looks around the barn. Two hundred faces looking back. Danny puts a hand on his shoulder.

Tito leans to the microphone.

TITO
(into the mic)
Tres... dos... uno.

EXT. TRANQUILITY BASE - CONTINUOUS

Gunny's glove closes the circuit.

The first shell rides a hard straight spark into the black
— no arc, no drift, dead true — and breaks.

RED. A perfect sphere, edges clean, expanding and
expanding and not stopping, no air to slow it, and no
sound at all.

INT. ROY'S DINER - CONTINUOUS

The whole room lit red off the TV. Nobody blinks.

EXT. TRANQUILITY BASE - CONTINUOUS

The second shell breaks WHITE — a sphere inside the fading
red one, rings within rings, drifting up through itself in
the vacuum.

EXT. DAWES FARMHOUSE, PORCH - NIGHT

Peg on the porch, the TV's glow through the window laying
white light across her face. Her hand is on the porch
light switch. She leaves it on, steady now.

EXT. TRANQUILITY BASE - CONTINUOUS

The white sphere hangs over the six flags and the small
fifty-one-star one. Cricket steps forward, next to the
first flag, the one raised back up where it fell.

He keys the open loop — to the crew, to the diner, to
Warsaw, to the barn, to Geneva, to every person on the lit
face of the Earth.

CRICKET
It's Independence Day.

A beat. The whole channel, the whole planet, quiet.

CRICKET

God bless America.

Gunny closes the circuit on the third tube.

The shell rides its spark up past the flags, up past the white sphere's last embers, and breaks BLUE-WHITE, dead center over the ring, a sphere that swells until it takes the entire frame —

WHITE OUT.

Hold in the white. Silence.

CUT TO:

EXT. TRANQUILITY BASE - LUNAR DAY

Days later. The party looks lived-in now: cable runs, a supply line of cases walked over from the Harmony lander, the flags holding their ring.

At the lander, load-up. Stitch and Dutch carry the last cases up the ramp. Gunny walks crate F's remaining stores the other way — toward the base station — stacking them neat without being asked.

Brandt watches Cricket, who has not started for the ramp.

BRANDT

We have four couches rigged.

CRICKET

Three's enough.

Brandt looks at him. At the ring of flags. Back at him. Then he nods once, and goes to supervise the loading.

Dutch comes down the ramp with his binder. He opens the rings, pulls a section — pages of margins, tables, his own handwriting — and hands them over.

DUTCH

Consumable margins, four pages.
The scrubber schedule is non-
negotiable. It's initialed.

CRICKET

It would be.

Gunny sets the last stores case down, squares it to the stack, and faces Cricket. He doesn't say anything. He comes to attention and holds out his hand, and they shake, one pump, done.

Stitch is last, at the foot of the ramp.

STITCH

Same time Tuesday.

CRICKET

I'll have the net up.

Stitch climbs the ramp without looking back.

INT. HARMONY ONE, CABIN - LATER

Cramped. Three old men webbed into rigged restraints among three astronauts in couches, knees and elbows everywhere. Foil-wrapped burgers pass hand to hand, cold.

Lindqvist takes two, holds one out to Shen wedged beside him.

Shen looks at it. Takes it. Unwraps it, and eats.

Nobody says anything about it. Dutch, chewing, produces his pencil and starts a fuel-margin calculation on the foil.

EXT. TRANQUILITY BASE - CONTINUOUS

Cricket stands clear of the blast radius, alone by the ring.

The ascent engine lights, silent. The lander rises on its spark, up and over, dust settling in slow sheets — and he holds a salute until it's one bright point among the stars.

Then he turns, and walks back to the flags, bootprints joining the hundreds already there.

CUT TO:

INT. ROY'S DINER - DAY

Months on. The TV, sound low: C-SPAN. The vote board fills green.

CHYRON: RESTORATION OF FLIGHT STATUS ACT PASSES 98-2.
BACKUP CREWS OF THE APOLLO PROGRAM ENTERED INTO THE ROLLS.

BUCK

Who were the two?

EARLENE

Does it matter?

BUCK

I'd like to know their addresses
is all.

The Cook sets a plate in front of a stranger. The carbon meter is gone off the gas line — four screw holes where it sat.

INT. DAWES FARMHOUSE, KITCHEN - DAY

Peg at the table with the mail. She opens a government envelope — linen again, eagle again.

INSERT — A PAY STUB: DAWES, E. — RANGER (FIRST),
TRANQUILITY BASE NATIONAL HISTORIC PARK. And a number, a real one, with digits.

Peg reads it twice. Puts it under a magnet on the fridge, square, where the family can see it.

The hutch drawer with the old check in it stays shut.

INT. DAWES BARN - NIGHT (TUESDAY)

The simulator hums on standby. DANNY sits at the ham rig with a mug, headset on, logbook open — a fresh spiral notebook, his own handwriting on the spine.

DANNY

(into the mic)

Net's open. Tuesday, nineteen-oh-
two local.

DUTCH (FILTERED)

Copy.

STITCH (FILTERED)

Here.

GUNNY (FILTERED)

On time for once, son.

A pause. Static, long-traveled, three seconds of light-lag round trip.

CRICKET (FILTERED)

(far, thin, clear)

Tranquility. Reading you loud and clear.

Danny grins at the rig and writes the time in the log.

EXT. TRANQUILITY BASE NATIONAL HISTORIC PARK - LUNAR NIGHT

A small hab module sits off the original site, resupply pods beside it. A carved sign faces the footprint trail:

TRANQUILITY BASE NATIONAL HISTORIC PARK — EST. JULY 4 —
RANGER STATION NO. 1.

The six flags stand their ring, colors lit by Earthlight. Over the hab, on its workshop pole, the fifty-one-star flag.

CRICKET — suit patched at the knee, an arrowhead park patch on his chest — walks the ring's perimeter, checking each staff with one glove, a firm pull at each.

He finishes at the first flag, the one from 1969, and looks up.

The Earth hangs full above the flags, night side facing — dark continents rimmed in city light.

Cricket raises one glove, all the way, and waves.

A beat.

On the dark face of the Earth: a city flickers. Then another. Then whole coastlines, pulsing — two, pause, two — the wave rolling westward across the night side, city by city, sea to sea.

Cricket holds his glove up, and the Earth keeps answering,
and the flags hold their colors in the black.

FADE OUT.

THE END